

THE MOST IMPORTANT DAY IN THE JOURNEY OF THE SOUL

Reflections by
His Holiness Radhanatha Swami Mahārāja

Harinām-dīkṣā Initiation Lectures
7–11 March 2026

ISKCON Govardhan Eco Village
Wada, Palghar, Maharashtra

Preface

Between 7 and 11 March 2026, His Holiness Radhanatha Swami Mahārāja presided over a series of harinām-dīkṣā initiation ceremonies at the Govardhan Eco Village (GEV), Wada, Palghar — the spiritual and ecological community established in the hills of Maharashtra, approximately eighty kilometres north of Mumbai, under the auspices of ISKCON.

Each ceremony was preceded by an extended lecture in which Mahārāja, with characteristic depth and warmth, guided the initiates and assembled devotees through the philosophical foundations of initiation, the living inheritance of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya, and the practical meaning of the commitment they were about to make. Over five consecutive days — the last of which fell on the most auspicious appearance day of Śrī Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura — he covered an extraordinary range of subjects: the nature of the soul and the Supreme, the grace of Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu, the sacrifice of Śrīla Prabhupāda, the inconceivable potency of the holy name, and the spirit in which a devotee must chant, serve, and live.

This booklet brings together all five lectures in the order in which they were delivered, beginning with the lecture of 7 March and concluding with that of 11 March. Each lecture has been transcribed from the original audio, presented in the first person as spoken, with transcription errors corrected throughout, Sanskrit terms restored with standard IAST diacritics, and all ślokas identified with their canonical sources. Each lecture's appendices — Sanskrit verses with full diacritics, historical and biographical notes, and glossaries of key terms — have been retained in full and follow immediately after the respective lecture.

The title of this booklet, The Most Important Day in the Journey of the Soul, reflects the recurring insight that runs through all five lectures: that the day of dīkṣā — the day on which a devotee formally commits to the mercy of the paramparā, to the chanting of the holy names, and to a life of sincere devotional service — is unlike any other day. It is the day on which the eternal soul consciously steps into the current of divine grace that has been flowing, uninterrupted, since the very beginning of creation. It is the day of saying yes to Kṛṣṇa's promise.

May these reflections serve as a lasting source of inspiration, philosophical grounding, and devotional nourishment for all those who took initiation during these sacred days — and for all those who read these pages seeking to understand the gift they have received.

*Govardhan Eco Village
March 2026*

Contents

Preface	2
Initiation Lecture — 7 March 2026	7
1. Opening Invocation — Honouring the Lineage	7
2. The Purification Verse — Apavitraḥ Pavitro Vā	7
3. Glorification of Lord Kṛṣṇa — The All-Attractive Supreme	7
4. The Holy Name as the Descent of the Spiritual World	8
5. Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — Kṛṣṇa in the Role of the Devotee	9
6. Śrīla Prabhupāda — The Empowered Ācārya	10
7. The Auspicious Historical Confluence — 1486 · 1896 · 1966 · 2026	10
8. Prabhupāda's Diary — Gaura Pūrṇimā, 1966, New York	11
9. Prabhupāda's Gift — Kṛṣṇa Consciousness for the World	11
10. The Paris Conversation — Prabhupāda and Pune	12
11. The Teaching Given — Completeness and Maturity	12
12. The Meaning of This Initiation	13
13. Three Sacred Principles — Hari-nāma, Vaiṣṇava-sevā, Jīva-dayā	13
14. The Question of Qualification — Grace, Not Merit	14
15. Closing Blessings and Prayers	14
Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (7 March)	15
Key Terms and Names — 7 March	15
Initiation Lecture — 8 March 2026	17
1. Opening Invocation — Entering the Sacred Stream	17
2. The Purification Verse — Apavitraḥ Pavitro Vā	17
3. The Purpose of Human Existence — Why We Suffer, Why We Seek	17
4. The Water Drop — A Meditation on Purification	18
5. The Completeness of the Lord — Pūrṇam Adaḥ Pūrṇam Idam	19
6. Kṛṣṇa's Mercy — The Holy Name as His Own Presence	19
7. The Gravity of This Commitment	20
8. The Message of Lord Caitanya — The Inconceivable Gift of Kali-yuga	21
9. The First Meeting — Calcutta, 1922	21
10. The Precedent — Senior Disciples Sent to England and Germany	22
11. The Jaladūta — 1965	22
12. Two Certainties in an Uncertain World	22
13. Śrīla Prabhupāda's Books — The Transmission of Wisdom	23
14. Gosvāmī Mahārāja and Book Distribution	23

15. His Holiness Jayapatākā Swami — The Living Example	23
16. The Common Thread — Commitment to the Guru.....	25
17. Three Sacred Pillars — Nāma-ruci, Vaiṣṇava-sevā, Jīva-dayā	25
18. The Light of Pune — Gratitude.....	26
19. Closing Prayers — A Heart Full of Gratitude.....	26
Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (8 March)	27
Historical and Biographical Notes — 8 March.....	27
Key Terms — 8 March.....	28
Initiation Lecture — 9 March 2026	30
1. Opening Invocation — The Maṅgalācaraṇa and Praṇāma Mantras.....	30
2. Welcome to Govardhan Eco Village	30
3. The Yuga-dharma — The Verse That Defines This Age	30
4. The Nature of Kali-yuga — Degradation and the Greatest Gift.....	31
5. The Nature of a True Devotee — Freedom from Envy	32
6. Navadvīpa Before the Appearance — The Suffering of the Saints.....	32
7. Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu — The Most Magnanimous Incarnation.....	33
8. The Garland of Holy Names — Kṛṣṇa-nāma and Kṛṣṇa-prīti	34
9. The Kāzī's Opposition — Saṅkīrtana Tested by Power	34
10. Caitanya Mahāprabhu's Departure — South Indian Pilgrimage.....	35
11. The South Indian Pilgrimage — Sacred Places Visited.....	36
12. The Philosophy of the Supreme Dharma	36
13. Jīva Gosvāmī — The Rasācārya	37
14. The 1922 Commission — The Ocean Within a Simple Sentence.....	37
15. Śrīla Prabhupāda's Poem — A Beggar's Prayer.....	38
16. The Commitment — Duty and Gratitude.....	38
17. Unity in Diversity — The Principle of the Sampradāya	38
18. Lord Caitanya Walked and Śrīla Prabhupāda Circled the Globe.....	39
19. The Preciousness of Every Devotee.....	39
20. Closing Gratitude and Prayers	39
Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (9 March)	40
Key People, Places, and Terms — 9 March.....	41
Initiation Lecture — 10 March 2026	43
1. Opening Invocation — The Spirit of Praṇāma.....	43
2. The Foundation — Total Surrender to Kṛṣṇa.....	43
3. The Nine Processes of Devotional Service.....	44
4. The Power of Kṛṣṇa Over Māyā — The Ocean and the Hoofprint.....	44
5. The Mahā-mantra — 32 Syllables, 16 Words, 3 Names, One Prayer	45

6. The Purification Verse — In All Situations of Life	45
7. How to Chant — Like a Baby Calling Its Mother	46
8. The Deity — Kṛṣṇa's Mercy in Visible Form	46
9. Meditating on the Paramparā — Are We Really Surrendered?	47
10. Śrīla Prabhupāda — The Ocean Within a Single Instruction	47
11. The Breadth of Translation — Every Language on Earth	48
12. The Ācāryas of the Paramparā — A River of Living Grace	48
13. Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — The Gṛhasṭha Ācārya	49
14. The Pañca-tattva — Plundering the Storehouse of Love	49
15. What Is Initiation? — Honouring the Gift with Gratitude	50
16. The Formal Commitment — Connection to All the Ācāryas	50
17. The Structure of the Sampradāya — Serving Together	51
18. Closing Prayer	51
Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (10 March)	51
Key People, Concepts, and Terms — 10 March	52
Initiation Lecture — 11 March 2026	54
1. The Opening Verse — Pure or Impure, in All Situations	54
2. Kṛṣṇa as the Source of All — The Ontological Foundation	54
3. The Soul and the Supersoul — Sun and Sunray	54
4. Mahāprabhu's Teaching at Vārāṇasī — The Two-Month Discourse to Sanātana Gosvāmī	55
5. 'Bhakti Means to Serve' — A Memory from Vṛndāvana, August 1971	56
6. Kṛṣṇa's Pastimes — The Butter Thief and the Lord of All	56
7. Kṛṣṇa as the Supreme Proprietor — Everything Is His	57
8. Initiation — Connecting to the Paramparā	57
9. Mādhavendra Purī — The Root of the Tree	57
10. Lord Caitanya Takes Initiation — Teaching the Principle of Servitude	58
11. The Essence of Being a Devotee	58
12. Lord Caitanya Did Not Preach Until He Accepted Initiation	59
13. Īśvarapurī and Mādhavendra Purī — The Supreme Example of Service to the Guru	59
14. The Six Gosvāmīs — Establishing Vṛndāvana for the World	60
15. The Generation After — From Gosvāmīs to Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura	61
16. Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — The Bhajana at Home in the Forest	61
17. The Higher Taste — Param Drṣṭvā Nivartate	61
18. Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta and the 1922 Meeting — 1 Billion Names of Kṛṣṇa	62
19. Kṛṣṇa Has Incarnated in His Name — The Supreme Gift for Kali-yuga	62
20. The Commitment We Are Making Today	63
21. Rūpa Gosvāmī's Instruction — No Taste for Gossip	63

22. The Auspicious Day — The Appearance of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura	64
23. The Structure of the Community — Serving Together	64
Appendix A — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (11 March)	65
Appendix B — Historical and Devotional Notes (11 March)	66
Appendix C — Glossary of Key Terms (11 March)	66

7 March 2026

Initiation Lecture — 7 March 2026

Harinām-dīkṣā Ceremony

1. Opening Invocation — Honouring the Lineage

His Holiness Radhanath Swami opened the ceremony with a formal invocation on behalf of His Divine Grace A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda, honouring the worshipful ācāryas of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya — the Vaiṣṇava disciplic succession originating with Lord Brahmā and flowing through Madhvācārya and ultimately Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu's followers.

This opening situates the ceremony squarely within the framework of paramparā — the unbroken chain of transcendental knowledge transmission from guru to disciple — giving the initiates a sense of the immense lineage into which they are formally entering. The Sampradāya is not merely an institutional affiliation; it is a living river of divine grace descending from the topmost realm of Goloka Vṛndāvana.

The ceremony being conducted is specifically harinām-dīkṣā — initiation into the chanting of the holy names of the Lord — which Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu established as the foremost path for self-realisation in the age of Kali-yuga.

2. The Purification Verse — Apavitraḥ Pavitro Vā

The first śhloka recited during the ceremony was a purification mantra that Śrīla Prabhupāda taught devotees to meditate upon before undertaking further spiritual commitments:

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvānasthāṇi gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bāhyābhyantaraḥ śuciḥ ||

Translation: Whether one is pure or impure, or has passed through all the varied conditions of life, one who remembers the lotus-eyed Supreme Personality of Godhead becomes purified both within and without.

(Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra)

By opening with this verse, Radhanath Swami establishes the fundamental principle that eligibility for initiation is not contingent upon external purity or past circumstances. The sole qualification is the sincere desire to remember and take shelter of the Lord. This is an expression of the extraordinary compassion of both Kṛṣṇa and the guru: no one need disqualify themselves on grounds of prior impurity. The act of remembrance itself — and the commitment to begin anew — is the purifying agent.

3. Glorification of Lord Kṛṣṇa — The All-Attractive Supreme

Radhanath Swami then offered an extended glorification of Lord Kṛṣṇa, unpacking the meaning and significance of the Lord's name and nature.

Kṛṣṇa as the All-Attractive: The name Kṛṣṇa itself reveals the Lord's essential nature. Etymologically, Kṛṣṇa derives from the Sanskrit root kṛṣ (to attract) and ṇa (spiritual bliss), indicating the one who attracts all living beings toward transcendental bliss. He possesses all ṣaḍ-aiśvarya — the six opulences in their complete fullness for all of eternity: unlimited beauty (rūpa), unlimited strength (bala), unlimited fame (yaśas), unlimited knowledge (jñāna), unlimited renunciation (vairāgya), and unlimited wealth (śrī).

Kṛṣṇas tu Bhagavān Svayam: Drawing upon the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam's own testimony:

ete caṁśa-kalaḥ puṁsaḥ kṛṣṇas tu bhagavān svayam | indrāri-ryākulaṁ lokaṁ mṛḍayanti yuge yuge ||

Translation: All the lists of the incarnations of Godhead submitted herewith are either plenary portions or portions of the plenary portions of the Lord, but Kṛṣṇa is the original Personality of Godhead Himself. In every age He protects the worlds when they are disturbed by the enemies of Indra.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.3.28)

Kṛṣṇa is thus the svayam bhagavān — the primeval, self-complete Supreme Personality of Godhead, from whom all incarnations and all existence emanate. Every other form of the Lord — Viṣṇu, Nārāyaṇa, Rāma, and countless others — is an expansion or manifestation of this original source.

Yad Yad Vibhūtimat: Quoting the Bhagavad-gītā's declaration:

yad yad vibhūtimat sattvaṁ śrīmad ūrjitam eva vā | tat tad evāvagaccha tvaṁ mama tejo-'ṁśa-sambhavam ||

Translation: Know that all opulent, beautiful, and glorious creations spring from but a spark of My splendour.

(Bhagavad-gītā 10.41)

Whatever beauty, power, excellence, or opulence we encounter anywhere — in the material or spiritual worlds — is but a tiny fraction, a single spark, of Kṛṣṇa's infinite radiance. This teaching from the Bhagavad-gītā invites the devotee to see the whole of existence as an expression of Kṛṣṇa's glory, naturally redirecting all appreciation and wonder back to its source.

4. The Holy Name as the Descent of the Spiritual World

Radhanath Swami then entered the heart of the ceremony's philosophy — the transcendental nature of the holy name itself.

Rādhārāṇī and Kṛṣṇa fully manifest in the Name: He declared that Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī and Lord Kṛṣṇa have fully manifested themselves within the divine sound of their holy names. The name is not a mere symbol or a pointer to the Lord — it is the Lord, present in the form of transcendental sound vibration (śabda-brahman). This is the unique gift of the Vaiṣṇava tradition: the Supreme Absolute has made Himself directly accessible through sound.

Descent from the Spiritual World: The Mahā-mantra and the names of Śrī Gaura-Hare-Kṛṣṇa in the form of saṅkīrtana have descended from the highest realm of the spiritual world — from Goloka, the topmost planet in the spiritual sky. They are not human inventions or cultural constructs. They are divine gifts, brought down by the mercy of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu for the liberation of all souls in Kali-yuga.

Param Vijayate — The Śikṣāṣṭaka: Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu Himself declared, in the first verse of His Śikṣāṣṭaka:

*ceto-darpaṇa-mārjanam bhava-mahā-dāvāgni-nirvāpanam śreyah-kairava-candrikā-vitaranam |
anandāmbudhi-vardhanam prati-padam pūṇāmṛtāsvādanam sarvātma-snāpanam param vijayate śrī-kṛṣṇa-
saṅkīrtanam | |*

Translation: Let there be all glory to the saṅkīrtana of Śrī Kṛṣṇa, which cleanses the mirror of the heart and extinguishes the great forest fire of material existence. It causes the lotus of good fortune to bloom, it is the life of transcendental knowledge, it increases the ocean of transcendental bliss, and it enables us to fully taste the nectar for which we are always anxious. It bathes every atom of the self in transcendence. All glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana!

(Śikṣāṣṭaka 1, by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Antya-līlā 20.12)

The Swami emphasised Mahāprabhu's proclamation: Kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana is the greatest, most supreme benediction (param vijayate) for all living entities. It is not merely one spiritual practice among many — it is the paramo dharma, the supreme path for this age, declared so by Kṛṣṇa Himself appearing as Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu.

5. Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — Kṛṣṇa in the Role of the Devotee

The Various Incarnations: Reading in Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam and other scriptures about the many incarnations of the Lord — each revealing the Lord's power, beauty, mercy, and love — culminates in the understanding of Kṛṣṇa as svayam bhagavān, the original source. But in Kali-yuga, Kṛṣṇa appeared in a uniquely secret and supremely compassionate form.

Kṛṣṇa as Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu: He came in the age of Kali-yuga as Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — Kṛṣṇa Himself, appearing in the mood and golden complexion of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī, to taste the supreme sweetness of Her love for Kṛṣṇa. This is the esoteric understanding of Mahāprabhu's appearance, confirmed throughout the Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta.

Mahāprabhu's Magnanimity — Audārya: Radhanath Swami described Mahāprabhu as supremely audāra — supremely magnanimous — because He freely distributes rāga-bhakti, the highest form of pure love of God from the topmost realm of Goloka Vṛndāvana, in an age (Kali-yuga) when practically no one could possibly deserve or qualify to receive it. This is the miracle: the gift is given precisely because humanity is unqualified. Mercy does not calculate qualification; it flows from the overflowing ocean of compassion.

How He distributes: Mahāprabhu distributes this supreme love through His teachings, through the pastimes described in scripture, through the hearts of His devotees, and — most directly and accessibly — through the holy names of Kṛṣṇa.

Placing the garland upon the world: Quoting from Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Radhanath Swami described how Mahāprabhu placed the garland of the holy names of Kṛṣṇa — and the pure, unmotivated, uninterrupted ecstatic love of God — around the entire world. This is the spiritual inheritance of every living being, offered freely without distinction.

6. Śrīla Prabhupāda — The Empowered Ācārya

The Lineage of Ācāryas: Throughout the disciplic succession — through the greatest ācāryas and intimate associates of Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa in Goloka Vṛndāvana, who descended to carry out Mahāprabhu's mission of compassion and love — one figure stands uniquely empowered for the modern world.

Śrīla Prabhupāda: His Divine Grace A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda, the beloved ācārya of the Vaiṣṇava world, came with the full mercy, the full realisation, and the perfect path to the highest perfection. He was not merely a teacher — he was a direct channel of the grace of Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa and of the Gauḍīya Sampradāya.

His Residence in Vṛndāvana: Prabhupāda was living at the Rādhā-Dāmodara temple in Vṛndāvana, translating the first canto of Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, deeply pondering, meditating, and praying. He was immersing himself in the realisations of all the preceding ācāryas and, in pure compassion, praying to Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī and the ācāryas to enable him to fulfil the order of his own Guru Mahārāja.

The Order of His Guru Mahārāja: His Guru Mahārāja — Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura — had given the directive at their very first meeting and reaffirmed it at their last communication: 'You are an educated young man. Take the teachings of Śrī Caitanya to the whole world, in the English language.'

Śrīla Prabhupāda took this instruction as his life and soul. It became the mission to which he dedicated his entire being — his energy, his intelligence, his words, his very last breath.

7. The Auspicious Historical Confluence — 1486 · 1896 · 1966 · 2026

Radhanath Swami paused to draw attention to a remarkable and spiritually significant alignment of dates, noting that Gaura Pūrṇimā 2026 was just a few days away from the ceremony:

1486	Appearance of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu (Navadvīpa, West Bengal)
1896	Appearance of Śrīla A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda (Kolkata)
1966	Founding of ISKCON; Prabhupāda begins his movement in the West

Each date marks an interval of exactly 530 years, 70 years, and 60 years respectively — a cascade of divine appointments descending into history. The Swami noted that 2026 is especially auspicious, with the initiates having had to 'wait an extra year' — implying that the alignment of this Gaura Pūrṇimā with this ceremony was itself an expression of divine timing.

8. Prabhupāda's Diary — Gaura Pūrṇimā, 1966, New York

Radhanath Swami shared a deeply moving personal account of having recently been reading Śrīla Prabhupāda's personal diary from 1966, specifically the entry written on Gaura Pūrṇimā — the appearance day of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — that year.

The Entry: Prabhupāda writes (paraphrased and reconstructed from the transcription): 'Today, according to the Vaiṣṇava calendar, it is Gaura Pūrṇimā — the appearance day of Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu. And I am all alone here, without the association of any devotee, without any means. Today, in Vṛndāvana, in Navadvīpa, all the Vaiṣṇavas are enjoying glorious festivals together. But I am alone here. Yet I am very happy, because this is the instruction of my Guru Mahārāja — that I fulfil the order of Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu: to take the holy name of Kṛṣṇa and Kṛṣṇa consciousness to the whole world.'

The Swami's Reflection: Radhanath Swami was deeply moved by this entry. In 1966, Prabhupāda was in New York — alone, without resources, without community, physically far from the sacred sites of Vṛndāvana and Navadvīpa. While the entire Vaiṣṇava world was celebrating Gaura Pūrṇimā in sacred assembly, the great ācārya sat in solitude in the West. And yet, his joy was complete — because he was living in perfect alignment with his Guru Mahārāja's instruction. Obedience to the guru was itself his festival.

This episode illustrates one of the most profound teachings of the Vaiṣṇava tradition: that the guru's instruction, faithfully held, becomes the devotee's shelter, community, and celebration — transcending all external circumstances.

9. Prabhupāda's Gift — Kṛṣṇa Consciousness for the World

The Double Gift: Śrīla Prabhupāda gave two inseparable gifts: first, the teachings of Kṛṣṇa consciousness themselves — the philosophy, the practice, the devotional culture; and second, the supreme blessing of participating in his mission — of sharing the very work to which he gave his entire life.

Building Kṛṣṇa Consciousness Communities: After establishing the movement, Prabhupāda directed most of his energy toward building Kṛṣṇa consciousness communities, particularly in India. He wanted all Indians — directly or indirectly — to help spread Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu's

message of mercy to the whole world. He understood India's unique spiritual heritage as a resource for the entire human family, not merely a national inheritance.

The Gradual Blossoming of the Congregation: Gradually, congregational communities blossomed. In Vṛndāvana and across India, dedicated devotees — including Kṛṣṇānanda Prabhu, Rādhēśyāma Prabhu, Jayadeva Prabhu, and many others — served as pillars of this expansion.

At Govardhan Eco Village: At GEV — located in Wada, Palghar district, approximately 80 km north of Mumbai — the faithful attracted souls to the most glorious temples. The community has been actively engaged in:

- Serving Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana — the presiding Deities of GEV's temples
- Expanding the Rādhā-Kuñja-Bihārī temple — the ISKCON Pune Camp temple
- Developing ISKCON NVCC Pune and its presiding Deities Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra
- Nurturing numerous satellite temples radiating outward across the region
- Sending devotees — both congregational gṛhasthas and brahmacārīs — across the world to expand Kṛṣṇa consciousness

10. The Paris Conversation — Prabhupāda and Pune

On the very morning of the ceremony, Radhanath Swami had been listening to a room conversation recording of Śrīla Prabhupāda in Paris, France. In this conversation, Prabhupāda was introduced to a Western man who had lived in India. When Prabhupāda asked which part of India the man had lived in, the man replied: 'Pune.'

Prabhupāda's response was one of immediate joy and warmth. He exclaimed, 'Pune! If you have lived 25 years in Pune, then you are in India!' — and proceeded to describe with great affection how wonderful Pune was, sharing precisely where he himself had stayed in Pune and what he had done there.

The Swami's Wonder: That this was the recording he happened to hear on the very morning of this initiation ceremony — held at Govardhan Eco Village in Wada, Palghar, with initiates drawn largely from the Pune congregation — moved Radhanath Swami deeply. He described feeling overwhelmed by this coincidence, seeing in it Śrīla Prabhupāda's invisible but ever-present blessings upon the Pune community. Prabhupāda's affection for Pune had somehow found its way into that morning's listening, as if the ācārya himself were present and acknowledging the ceremony.

'I am overwhelmed to be with all of you. I thank you with all my heart. I thank you for assisting in this great mission of Śrīla Prabhupāda, our Param Guru, Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu.'

11. The Teaching Given — Completeness and Maturity

Radhanath Swami affirmed that what Śrīla Prabhupāda gave was not a fragmentary or introductory teaching. He gave: the full teachings of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; in a mature, compassionate, and

complete way; as transmitted to him by his own Guru Mahārāja, Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura.

The family of Śrīla Prabhupāda's descendants — dīkṣā-gurus (initiating spiritual masters), śikṣā-gurus (instructing spiritual masters), temple presidents, G.B.C. members, pujārīs, saṅkīrtana devotees, congregational devotees — all serve together with a single purpose: to fulfil and transmit the sharing of Kṛṣṇa consciousness.

12. The Meaning of This Initiation

The Grace of the Guru: Radhanath Swami reminded the initiates that Śrīla Prabhupāda does not merely belong to the past. He comes — through the dīkṣā-gurus, through the śikṣā-gurus, through the feasts, through senior Vaiṣṇavas — as a living current of divine grace. That same current of grace is flowing through all members of the community, shared among each other.

A Formal Commitment: This initiation is the moment of making a formal, solemn commitment — a commitment to:

1. Remain faithful and loyal to the teachings of Śrīla Prabhupāda, both in form and in spirit
2. Read, understand, and share Prabhupāda's books according to one's capacity
3. Sincerely take shelter of and worship Kṛṣṇa's holy names
4. Follow the character and moral principles of a Vaiṣṇava

The Four Regulative Principles: In form, this means following the four fundamental principles of Vaiṣṇava conduct: no illicit sex, no intoxication, no gambling, no meat-eating (flesh, fish, or eggs).

In Spirit: But Radhanath Swami stressed that the commitment extends far deeper than these four prohibitions. In spirit, the initiates are committing themselves to live as Vaiṣṇavas: to rise above envy — to transcend the tendency to begrudge others' good fortune; to rise above greed — to relinquish the endless hunger for material acquisition; to rise above fault-finding — to abandon the habit of searching for and broadcasting others' flaws; to genuinely uplift other Vaiṣṇavas — to be a source of encouragement, support, and inspiration; and together, to uplift the world through Kṛṣṇa's holy name and through Prabhupāda's mercy.

13. Three Sacred Principles — Hari-nāma, Vaiṣṇava-sevā, Jīva-dayā

Radhanath Swami articulated three foundational sacred principles that form the spiritual backbone of the commitment being undertaken. These four intertwined principles — found throughout Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇava literature and given special emphasis by Śrīla Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura and Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — are here grouped into three sacred arcs of commitment:

1. Taking shelter of the Holy Name (Hari-nāma-āśraya): To sincerely and earnestly take refuge in the divine sound of Kṛṣṇa's name — not as a mechanical exercise, but with nāma-ruci, a genuine taste and loving attachment to the chanting. This is the central pillar of practice.

2. Serving the Lord's Devotees (Vaiṣṇava-sevā): To offer genuine service, honour, and care to the community of Vaiṣṇavas — seeing each devotee as a representative and embodiment of the Lord's mercy. This includes serving one's guru, one's godbrothers and godsisters, and all who are striving sincerely.

3. Compassion for All Living Beings (Jīva-dayā): To be instruments through whom Kṛṣṇa's grace can flow outward to the world — serving as channels of Prabhupāda's mission, sharing Kṛṣṇa consciousness with all souls regardless of background, qualification, or circumstance.

The Swami stated plainly: 'We are committing ourselves to honestly and earnestly trying our very best to apply these sacred principles to our lives.'

14. The Question of Qualification — Grace, Not Merit

What qualifies a soul to receive Mahāprabhu's gift? When Śrīla Prabhupāda was asked about the qualification to receive what Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu is distributing — rāgānugā-bhakti, the pure love of the Gopas and Gopīs in the highest realm of Goloka Vṛndāvana, beyond Vaikuṇṭha, beyond Dvārakā — his answer was disarmingly simple: 'I made her qualification.' That is: Caitanya Mahāprabhu creates the qualification by giving the gift. Qualification arises from receiving the mercy, not from earning it. This is the radical generosity at the heart of Mahāprabhu's mission.

A Reminder to All: We may be very simple, doing very small service. Or we may become famous and highly empowered. But all of us are completely and utterly dependent on the higher power of the mercy we receive. The recognition of this truth — not merely intellectually but in daily experience — is what binds the community together. 'The more we all recognise this and commit ourselves to appreciate and live by this principle, we can really have a united community — a community where there is real unity, and where we see the diversity among us as something very glorious.'

15. Closing Blessings and Prayers

Radhanath Swami concluded with an expression of gratitude so complete that it reached beyond all formal language: He thanked the devotees on behalf of Śrīla Prabhupāda's entire Guru-vṛnda — the community of spiritual masters. He prayed for the assembled devotees on behalf of Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī — the presiding Deities of GEV — and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra — the presiding Deities of ISKCON NVCC Pune, from whose congregation the initiates came. He prayed that their mercy, blessings, and grace flow upon each and every one of the devotees. He prayed that the devotees be empowered to do wonderful things in Their service.

'On behalf of Śrīla Prabhupāda and our Guru-vṛnda, I pray for you. I pray that Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana, Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī, and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra — Their

mercy, Their blessings, Their grace — be upon you and empower you to do wonderful things in Their service.'

Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (7 March)

A. Purification Mantra (Śuddhi-mantra)

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvāvasthaṁ gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bahyābhyantarah śuciḥ ||
Source: Traditional Vaiṣṇava purification mantra; incorporated into ISKCON ceremonial liturgy by Śrīla Prabhupāda.

B. Kṛṣṇas tu Bhagavān Svayam

ete caṁśa-kalaḥ puṁsaḥ kṛṣṇas tu bhagavān svayam | indrāri-vyakulaṁ lokaṁ mṛḍayanti yuge yuge ||
Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.3.28

C. Vibhūti-yoga — All Opulence Comes from Kṛṣṇa

yad yad vibhūtimat sattvaṁ śrīmad ūrjitam eva vā | tat tad evāgaccha tvaṁ mama tejo-'mśa-sambhavam ||
Source: Bhagavad-gītā 10.41

D. Śikṣāṣṭaka — Verse 1 (Param Vijayate)

*ceto-darpaṇa-mārjanam bhava-mahā-dāvāgni-nirvāpanam śreyah-kairava-candrikā-vitaranam vidyā-vadhu-jīvanam |
anandāmbudhi-vardhanam prati-padam pūṇamṛtāsādanam sarvātma-snapanam param vijayate śrī-kṛṣṇa-
saṅkīrtanam ||*
Source: Śikṣāṣṭaka 1, composed by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Antya-līlā 20.12.

E. Three Sacred Principles — Gauḍīya Teaching

Hari-nāma · Nāma-ruci · Vaiṣṇava-sevā · Jīva-dayā — These foundational values run through the works of Śrīla Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura, Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura, and Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura, and are codified in the practices of the Gauḍīya Maṭha and ISKCON.

Key Terms and Names — 7 March

Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya	The Vaiṣṇava disciplic succession from Brahmā through Madhvācārya and Gauḍīya (Caitanya's) line
Harinām-dīkṣā	Initiation into chanting the holy names of the Lord
Param vijayate	Let there be all victory / all glory to...
Svayam bhagavān	The original Personality of Godhead Himself
Ṣaḍ-aiśvarya	The six full divine opulences
Audārya	Magnanimity; the quality of supreme generosity
Saṅkīrtana	Congregational glorification of the Lord's holy names
Rāgānugā-bhakti	Spontaneous devotional love following in the wake of the eternal associates

Goloka Vṛndāvana	The topmost planet of the spiritual world; Kṛṣṇa's eternal abode
Dīkṣā-guru	The initiating spiritual master who gives the first and second initiations
Śikṣā-guru	An instructing spiritual master from whom one receives guidance and inspiration
Guru-vṛnda	The community or assembly of spiritual masters
Gaura Pūrṇimā	The full moon celebration of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu's appearance
Rādhā-Dāmodara Temple	The historic Vṛndāvana temple where Śrīla Prabhupāda resided and began writing the Bhāgavatam
Ṣaḍ Gosvāmīs	The Six Gosvāmīs of Vṛndāvana: Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha Bhaṭṭa, Gopāla Bhaṭṭa, Raghunātha dāsa, and Jīva Gosvāmīs
Govardhan Eco Village (GEV)	ISKCON's sustainable spiritual community in Wada, Palghar district, Maharashtra (~80 km north of Mumbai)
Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī	Presiding Deities of GEV (1st shrine)
Rādhā-Madana-mohana	Presiding Deities of GEV (2nd shrine)
Rādhā-Kuñja-Bihārī	Presiding Deities of ISKCON Pune Camp temple
Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra	Presiding Deities of ISKCON NVCC, Pune
Paramparā	The unbroken disciplic succession of transcendental knowledge
Jīva-dayā	Compassion for all living souls
Nāma-ruci	A genuine taste and relish for chanting the holy name

8 March 2026

Initiation Lecture — 8 March 2026

Harinām-dīkṣā Ceremony

1. Opening Invocation — Entering the Sacred Stream

On behalf of His Divine Grace, His Divya-vigraha-dhārīṇī Haripriya Śrīla Prabhupāda, and in honour of all the worshipful ācāryas of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya, we now formally begin this initiation into harinām — the holy names of the Supreme Lord.

The Sampradāya is not an institution in the ordinary sense. It is a living river of divine grace, originating in the Lord Himself, flowing through Brahmā, through Madhvācārya, through the Six Gosvāmīs of Vṛndāvana, through Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura, and through Śrīla Prabhupāda — arriving now, in this very moment, here in this sacred place. When we receive dīkṣā, we are not merely joining an organisation. We are stepping into that river. We are being connected to a current of grace that has been flowing from the very beginning of creation.

2. The Purification Verse — Apavitraḥ Pavitro Vā

The verse I always ask us to chant together before all ceremonies of serious spiritual commitment is this:

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvāvasthām gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣam sa bahyābhyantarah śuciḥ ||

Translation: Whether one is pure or impure, or has passed through all the varied conditions and circumstances of life — one who remembers the lotus-eyed Supreme Personality of Godhead becomes purified both within and without.

(Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra, incorporated into ISKCON ceremonial liturgy by Śrīla Prabhupāda)

This verse, I find, reveals to us the entire spirit of initiation. Śrīla Prabhupāda had us chant this together for all ceremonies where serious commitments were being made in our spiritual life. It tells us something absolutely fundamental: the qualification for entering into the process of Kṛṣṇa consciousness is not a prerequisite level of purity. The Lord does not wait for us to become clean before He extends His mercy. The process itself — the remembrance, the chanting, the turning of the heart — is the purification.

3. The Purpose of Human Existence — Why We Suffer, Why We Seek

The purpose of human existence, as the Vedic tradition articulates it with extraordinary precision, is purification. The mind and the heart, in their conditioned state, are cluttered with so many pollutants. The ancient texts enumerate them clearly: kāma (lust), krodha (anger), lobha (greed), mātṣarya (envy), mada (arrogance), and moha (illusion). These are the anarthas — the unwanted

things, literally 'that which is not valuable' — and all of the suffering that manifests in our life flows directly from their presence.

In the grip of these anarthas, we live trapped within a paradox: what we think, what we speak, and what we do — all of it, in this state of material existence under the control of the three modes of nature, in our relentless pursuit of happiness — only implicates us more and more deeply in inevitable suffering. Birth, old age, disease, and death are the inescapable coordinates of conditioned life. No one escapes them by ignoring them.

And yet — our nature is to be happy. The Vedānta-sūtra declares this directly:

ānandamayo 'bhyāsāt

Translation: The Supreme Absolute Truth is by nature full of bliss, and this is confirmed by repetition.

(Vedānta-sūtra 1.1.12)

The soul, being a part of that Absolute, shares in this fundamental nature. From the tiniest insect to the greatest demigods dwelling in the higher planetary systems — every single living entity is seeking happiness, because happiness is our very nature. The ātman — the eternal self — is ānandamaya, naturally existing beyond birth, beyond death, beyond the three kinds of misery: ādhyātmika (suffering arising from one's own body and mind), ādhibhautika (suffering caused by other living beings), ādhidaivika (suffering arising from natural forces and higher powers).

So this is the great existential question: if the soul is by nature eternal, blissful, and self-satisfied — experiencing God's intimate love and feeling the all-pervading reality of God's presence within and without — then why do we suffer? The answer the tradition gives is at once simple and profound: because the mind is polluted. The soul itself is untouched, undimmed, eternally luminous. It is the accumulated conditioning of the mind that obscures that natural radiance.

4. The Water Drop — A Meditation on Purification

Śrīla Prabhupāda offers a strikingly beautiful and simple illustration of this at the very beginning of our movement. When a drop of water falls from a cloud, it is utterly transparent and clear. But the moment it comes into contact with the ground, it loses that transparency — it becomes muddy because it mixes with elements that are not at all part of the water's own nature. The mud is not the water; the cloudedness is not inherent. When we filter that water, we are not adding anything new — we are simply restoring its original natural quality. The purity was always there.

This is a perfect metaphor for what we are doing here today. The soul is that drop of water — pure by nature, transparent with divine love, luminous with God's presence. What we are undertaking in this ceremony of dīkṣā is not the manufacture of something new. It is the beginning of a lifelong process of returning to what we already are. Filtering out what was never really ours to begin with.

But the practical question immediately arises: in a world full of so many temptations, so many distractions, so many disconnections pulling us in every direction — how do we sustainably

become purified? This is precisely why this first verse is invoked. It points us to the supreme purifier, addressed as pavitra — supremely, infinitely pure.

5. The Completeness of the Lord — Pūrṇam Adah Pūrṇam Idam

The Absolute Truth is perfect and complete. This is the great declaration of the Vedic canon, sounded in the very opening invocation of the Īśopaniṣad:

om pūrṇam adah pūrṇam idam pūrṇāt pūrṇam udacyate | pūrṇasya pūrṇam ādāya pūrṇam evāvaśiṣyate ||

Translation: The Personality of Godhead is perfect and complete. And because He is completely perfect, all emanations from Him — such as this phenomenal world — are perfectly equipped as a complete whole. Whatever is produced of the complete whole is also complete by itself. And because He is the complete whole, even though so many complete units emanate from Him, He remains the complete balance.

(Śrī Īśopaniṣad, Invocation; also Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 5.1.1)

His love is perfect and complete. The happiness He gives is perfect and complete. And the happiness that we — as His eternal parts and parcels — have the potential to share with Him is likewise perfect and complete. When we remember Kṛṣṇa, when we come into contact with Kṛṣṇa, we become purified. This is not a metaphor. It is a metaphysical and experiential fact confirmed across the Vedic literature.

Śrīla Prabhupāda illustrates this with another example: when you come in contact with fire, you feel its heat. It is the nature of fire to radiate heat, and it is the nature of all things near fire to receive that radiance. Similarly, when we associate with Kṛṣṇa — because He is sarva-ākaraṣaṇa, all-attractive — we naturally become attracted. And the entire science of bhakti-yoga is the science of how to live in such a way that we remain in constant connection with Kṛṣṇa's infinite attraction. To associate with Kṛṣṇa is to become Kṛṣṇa-like. To become Kṛṣṇa-like is to become pure.

6. Kṛṣṇa's Mercy — The Holy Name as His Own Presence

I want to speak about something so merciful, so extraordinary, that the ācāryas describe it as Kṛṣṇa's greatest gift to this age. The verse that captures it is found in the Padma Purāṇa and is quoted by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu Himself:

nāma cintāmaṇiḥ kṛṣṇaś caitanya-rasa-vigrahaḥ | pūrṇaḥ śuddho nitya-mukto 'bhinnatvān nāma-nāminoḥ ||

Translation: The holy name of Kṛṣṇa is transcendently blissful. It bestows all spiritual benedictions, for it is Kṛṣṇa Himself — the reservoir of all pleasure. Kṛṣṇa's name is complete, and it is the form of all transcendental mellows. It is not a material name under any condition, and it is no less powerful than Kṛṣṇa Himself. Since Kṛṣṇa's name is not contaminated by the material qualities, there is no question of its being involved with māyā. Kṛṣṇa's name is always liberated and spiritual; it is never conditioned by the laws of material nature. This is because the name of Kṛṣṇa and Kṛṣṇa Himself are identical.

(Padma Purāṇa; cited in Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 17.133)

Kṛṣṇa is so merciful, so kind to us, that He invests within His holy names His own full presence. The name is not a finger pointing at the moon — the name is the moon. When we purely chant

the holy names of the Lord without offenses, as Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura and Śrīla Prabhupāda describe it, the chanting has a very cooling, soothing, healing effect — relieving us from the saṁsāra-dāvānala, the burning forest fire of material existence. This expression — saṁsāra-dāvānala — comes from the magnificent first verse of the Gurvaṣṭaka, composed by Śrīla Viśvanātha Cakravartī Ṭhākura:

*saṁsāra-dāvānala-lidha-loka-trāṇāya kārṇīya-ghanāghanatvam | prāptasya kalyāṇa-guṇāṇavasya vande guroḥ śrī-
caraṇāravindam ||*

Translation: The spiritual master is receiving benediction from the ocean of mercy. Just as a cloud pours water on a forest fire to extinguish it, so the spiritual master extinguishes the blazing fire of material existence. I offer my respectful obeisances unto the lotus feet of such a spiritual master.

(Śrī Gurvaṣṭaka 1, by Śrīla Viśvanātha Cakravartī Ṭhākura)

Everything in this world has its challenges. But Kṛṣṇa is so merciful — He incarnates within His very name, just to attract our hearts. And as we are attracted to Kṛṣṇa, we become purified.

When we experience the supremely ecstatic attraction of Kṛṣṇa — through His name, His pastimes, His form, His qualities, His presence in the hearts of His devotees, even His presence within the beauty of nature — then the insignificant things that people are so arrogant about, so greedy about, so envious and angry about in this world simply hold no attraction at all. The extraordinary eclipses the ordinary. The infinite makes the finite irrelevant.

7. The Gravity of This Commitment

We have come together today to commit ourselves formally — before our gurus, before our beloved worship-founder ācārya Śrīla Prabhupāda, who represents all the greatest ācāryas of our Sampradāya. Taking initiation, making this commitment according to the sincerity of our hearts, we are being directly connected to the grace, the mercy, and the love of Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa through all of our ācāryas. This is not any ordinary, simple, sub-material transaction. It is the supreme gift. And if we receive it in the proper spirit, we are truly, deeply humbled by it.

But I want to be honest with you about something — something the ācāryas always teach clearly: we will be tested. That is certain. It is not necessarily the case that things become easier after initiation. Sometimes they may even become more difficult. This is not because initiation causes difficulty. It is simply because that is the way the material world is. Taking initiation does not change the material world. The world remains what it is.

But it is we who change. Our commitment, our dedication — that is what shifts. According to the sincerity of how we try to surrender, we ourselves undergo a transformation. Kṛṣṇa tells us very clearly in the Bhagavad-gītā:

daivi hy eṣā guṇamayī mama māyā duratyayā | mām eva ye prapadyante māyām etāṁ taranti te ||

Translation: This divine energy of Mine, consisting of the three modes of material nature, is difficult to overcome. But those who have surrendered unto Me can easily cross beyond it.

He does not say material nature becomes easier. He says that being in the shelter of Kṛṣṇa makes everything auspicious. There is a profound and important distinction there. The obstacles are still real — the internal conditionings, the influences surrounding us, the complexities of human nature, the necessary struggle of navigating life in this world. There will be glorious and blissful festivals. And there will be tragedies — for everyone. This is the dualistic reality of material existence.

But we are committing ourselves, from this day forward, to say to Kṛṣṇa: 'I understand that I am an eternal spiritual soul, and I am Your eternal loving servant. Whatever comes — whatever triumph or reversal, whatever joy or sorrow the world brings — I cling, cling with all sincerity, to Your mercy, to Your grace.'

8. The Message of Lord Caitanya — The Inconceivable Gift of Kali-yuga

The message of Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu is an inconceivable good fortune bestowed upon this world — and specifically upon the age of Kali-yuga. Kali-yuga is an age characterised by quarrel, hypocrisy, gross materialism, suffering, and pollution pervading almost every dimension of life. What was possible in Satya-yuga — the first great age of spiritual perfection — and what the saints of Tretā-yuga and Dvāpara-yuga were expected to fulfil in terms of religious principles and dharma — is practically impossible for souls conditioned by the character of this present age.

And yet — Kṛṣṇa, in His supreme magnanimity, comes in this very fallen age with the supreme sweet love of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī. He comes to teach us, and more than that — to personally invite us into the eternal realm of His Vṛndāvana pastimes. There are many avatāras. There are many great founders of religion who teach various levels and dimensions of love of God and pure devotional consciousness. But Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu comes with the complexion and the mahā-bhāva — the supreme emotional state — of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī Herself. And He appears only once in a day of Brahmā — an unimaginably vast span of cosmic time — to so freely give this gift. This is the rarity and the preciousness of the moment in which we are all living.

9. The First Meeting — Calcutta, 1922

In Calcutta, in the year 1922, during their very first meeting, Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura Prabhupāda gave our Śrīla Prabhupāda a commission that would define the entire trajectory of his life and ultimately shape the spiritual destinies of millions of souls across the world: 'You are an educated young man. Bring the message of Lord Caitanya in the English language all over the world.'

No one had ever done this — not in the entire history of this world. No ācārya of the Gauḍīya tradition had ever systematically brought the complete philosophy and practice of Kṛṣṇa consciousness to the Western world in the English language. It was an unprecedented commission.

Śrīla Prabhupāda prepared his entire life for this purpose. That was 1922. In 1936, the very last instruction his Guru Mahārāja gave him — in a letter from Jagannātha Purī, at a time when Śrīla Prabhupāda was in Mumbai — was the same. The instruction did not waver, did not diminish over those fourteen years. If anything, it deepened in urgency: Go. Spread Caitanya's message. In English. To the whole world.

10. The Precedent — Senior Disciples Sent to England and Germany

It is very interesting — and something I was just hearing about in some of the historical accounts of Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura's life — that in the early 1930s, he had sent several of his very senior-most disciples to England and to Germany carrying the same message: Lord Caitanya's teachings. We actually saw newspaper articles — discovered and preserved by scholars and devotees — describing how Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura was living in Bombay, just next to the Babulnāth temple, giving lectures regularly there. He had arranged a wonderful ceremony, a formal send-off, for these senior disciples who were going to the West to establish Lord Caitanya's mission.

But the time was not fully ripe. There was not much success. They came back.

11. The Jaladūta — 1965

Then, in 1965 — forty-three years after that first instruction — Śrīla Prabhupāda boarded a cargo ship called the SS Jaladūta. He carried with him the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, the holy names of Kṛṣṇa, and the instruction of his Guru Mahārāja. That was really all he had. Nothing else. No one else.

What gave him the courage and the certainty to do what no one had done before — to sail alone, in his seventieth year, with no institutional support, no financial backing, no contacts in the West — was not organisational infrastructure. It was his absolute, unshakeable faith in the gifts of Lord Caitanya's teachings and the holy names of the Lord. He believed so deeply. And that faith alone was sufficient. The rest, as history shows, the Lord provided.

And not only did Śrīla Prabhupāda give us this extraordinary gift of Kṛṣṇa consciousness — but he so mercifully shared with us the opportunity to carry on this very mission. This is the double blessing. We are not merely beneficiaries. We are inheritors — entrusted with the mission he gave his entire life to fulfil.

12. Two Certainties in an Uncertain World

In this greatly divided world — a world of so many uncertainties, so many anxieties, so many things shifting beneath our feet — there are really only two certainties worth anchoring ourselves to.

The first certainty is universal and inescapable: death is certain — for everything and everyone we love, and for our own bodies. This is not a morbid observation. It is the beginning of wisdom.

The Vedic tradition teaches that only by honestly confronting this inevitability can we begin to make choices that are truly in our eternal interest.

The second certainty is the great gift of our tradition: Kṛṣṇa is not different from His name. The name of Kṛṣṇa is Kṛṣṇa Himself — fully present, fully accessible, fully capable of giving complete shelter. If we take shelter of the name of Kṛṣṇa, Kṛṣṇa gives us complete shelter. Nothing is withheld.

But it takes time. It takes determination. And — this is something I feel very strongly — we need each other's association to sustain our faith. We live in a world where almost everything around us is challenging that faith. The culture, the media, the relentless movement of material life — all of it pulls in directions away from Kṛṣṇa. This is precisely why the community of devotees — the sādhu-saṅga — is not a luxury. It is a necessity.

13. Śrīla Prabhupāda's Books — The Transmission of Wisdom

Śrīla Prabhupāda gave so much of his life — his time, his health, his energy — to writing his books, so that each of us could have the knowledge and wisdom of all our great ācāryas in our hands. He wrote so that we could share with one another and share with the world. So that we could preserve and expand our faith, our dedication, our determination.

The instruction from his Guru Mahārāja was to spread Lord Caitanya's message in the English language, all over the world. And Śrīla Prabhupāda fulfilled that instruction beyond any conceivable expectation: from the English language, his books and Lord Caitanya's teachings have been translated into more than 80 languages across the world. Into every major Indian language — especially Marathi, Hindi, Bengali, and more. Even now, the work continues. I asked Gaurāṅga Prabhu — how many languages? More than 80. Into almost every language on earth.

Think about this extraordinary journey: the Bhāgavata-sārasva — the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam — was originally composed in Sanskrit, translated masterfully from Sanskrit into Bengali, then from Bengali into English by Śrīla Prabhupāda with all purports — and then from English into 80 more languages. Each translation is another wave of Mahāprabhu's mercy crossing another border, entering another culture, touching another heart.

14. Gosvāmī Mahārāja and Book Distribution

And of course, here in Pune you have had the extraordinary blessing of the association of Śrī Śrī Gopāla Kṛṣṇa Gosvāmī Mahārāja, who has distributed more of Śrīla Prabhupāda's books than perhaps anyone in the history of the Kṛṣṇa consciousness movement. The contribution of Pune's devotees to the mission of book distribution is immeasurable — and it is a living expression of exactly the kind of loyalty to the guru's instruction that I want to speak about today.

15. His Holiness Jayapatākā Swami — The Living Example

In one of our recent Pune Yātrās — our annual pilgrimage gathering here in this region — something happened that I want to share with you as one of the most moving and instructive episodes I have personally witnessed in my life in Kṛṣṇa consciousness.

His Holiness Jayapatākā Swami Mahārāja had recently suffered a severe stroke. He was still in the hospital — barely able to speak, unable to walk, in a very serious and fragile health condition. I was speaking to him on the phone. And, simply wanting to make him feel encouraged, I mentioned that we were going to be holding the Pune Yātrā and that he was invited. I said there would be about 5,000 devotees.

A few days later, I received a very urgent call from the director of Bhaktivedānta Hospital, where Jayapatākā Mahārāja was being treated. They said to me: 'You have to help us. Jayapatākā Mahārāja is telling us he wants to go to the Pune Yātrā. But to bring him there, we would have to transport him by ambulance — it would take five or six hours each way. And all of our doctors unanimously agree: he probably could die doing this. He cannot do it. We are telling him no. And Jayapatākā Mahārāja is saying: 'Radhanath Swami is your guru. He invited me. You must make all the arrangements — otherwise you are disobeying your guru.'

The doctors were desperately pleading with me: 'Please withdraw your invitation. Tell him he should not come.'

And I was in an impossible position. How could I tell him not to come? He is my senior godbrother. He should have rolled back the debts that the Lord had sent him to discharge in this world. How could I, in good conscience, stand between him and that? The doctors insisted: 'He may die.'

So I came up with a plan. I asked them to go to the most senior surgeon who was treating him — a brilliant surgeon, not a devotee himself — the man who had performed several of Jayapatākā Mahārāja's brain operations. I asked them to have him tell Jayapatākā Mahārāja he could not go. Because he was not a devotee, he could say it. No devotee who knew Jayapatākā Mahārāja's stature in the movement could tell him no. He is senior to all of us.

They went to this very senior surgeon — I believe it was at Hinduja Hospital. And when they conveyed to him what the Bhaktivedānta Hospital doctors were saying — 'Please tell him he cannot go' — this remarkable man said the following: 'The best thing for Jayapatākā Swami's health will be to go to the Pune Yātrā. I have examined this person on every level. His whole life, his only happiness, is to give others Kṛṣṇa. So if there are 5,000 people there and he can give them all Kṛṣṇa, that will give him so much happiness. And there is nothing that will heal him better than happiness. So he should go.'

Do you remember what happened? Jayapatākā Mahārāja came — six hours lying in the back of an ambulance. They carried him out on a wheelchair and brought him before all 5,000 devotees. And he spoke. He hardly had any length of time. But he spoke. He gave his heart. And then he got back into the ambulance and went back to Bombay.

I was sitting right beside him when he spoke. So I could see all 5,000 devotees simultaneously. That means 10,000 eyes. And every one of them was shedding tears. Witnessing his dedication, his determination — to assist Śrīla Prabhupāda in sharing this Kṛṣṇa consciousness — despite every physical obstacle, despite every rational argument for not doing so. Because his guru had asked.

These are the examples. If we want to really make spiritual progress — these are the examples. We are so fortunate to have the opportunity to try to follow. We cannot imitate. But we can honour. We can draw inspiration. We can aspire.

16. The Common Thread — Commitment to the Guru

What was the unifying quality in Śrīla Prabhupāda's commitment to his Guru Mahārāja? In Śrīla Gopīparāñadhana Swami's commitment to his guru? In Śrīla Bhakti Cāru Swami's? In Śrīla Jayapatākā Swami's? In the entire Guru-vṛnda — the assembled community of spiritual masters in our tradition? Commitment to the guru. That is all. That is the entire secret.

This is what guru-paramparā ultimately means — not the recitation of a list of names, but the living transmission of this quality of absolute fidelity. And this is truly the spirit of initiation: committing ourselves to genuinely be the servant of the servant of our spiritual masters.

Dāsānudāsa. The servant of the servants. Not a student who admires from a distance, but a servant who actually serves — who actually follows. How do we follow? By receiving their teachings — reading, studying, reflecting upon Śrīla Prabhupāda's books; following very carefully — with Vaiṣṇava character, kāryakṣamatā (conscientious capacity); developing nāma-ruci — a genuine, personal taste for the chanting of the holy names — chanting sincerely, attentively, regularly.

17. Three Sacred Pillars — Nāma-ruci, Vaiṣṇava-sevā, Jīva-dayā

The commitment we are making today rests on three eternal pillars of Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇava practice, which run through the teachings of Śrīla Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura, Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura, and our entire ācārya-paramparā:

I. Nāma-ruci — The Taste for the Holy Name: The first pillar is developing a genuine, personal taste (ruci) for chanting the holy names of the Lord. This is not about mechanical completion of a quota. It is about allowing the name to enter the heart — chanting sincerely, attentively, regularly — and allowing that chanting to become, over time, the sweetest and most natural activity of our existence. Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu describes the progressive stages through which a devotee passes in approaching the name: first śraddhā (faith), then sādhu-saṅga (holy association), then bhajana-kriyā (regulated devotional practice), leading eventually to niṣṭhā (firm conviction), ruci (genuine taste), and ultimately āsakti and bhāva — deep loving attachment and the first rays of pure love of God. We may be at the earliest stages of this journey. That is completely fine. The only requirement is sincerity and beginning.

II. Vaiṣṇava-sevā — Serving the Community of Devotees: The second pillar is genuinely trying to encourage, inspire, and assist the Vaiṣṇava community. To see each devotee as a representative of the Lord's mercy — as someone infinitely precious, infinitely worthy of care and service. To rise above the tendency to find faults, to rise above envy of others' spiritual advancement, and to become, practically and consistently, a source of nourishment, encouragement, and upliftment for all those around us. This means serving our gurus — both the initiating guru (dikṣā-guru) and the instructing gurus (śikṣā-gurus) who guide us. It means serving our godbrothers and godsisters with genuine selflessness. It means building together the kind of community where everyone feels seen, valued, and supported in their sincere spiritual efforts.

III. Jīva-dayā — Compassion for All Living Souls: The third pillar is assisting the great ācāryas — and in particular our beloved Śrīla Prabhupāda — in sharing the message of Lord Caitanya with others. To be genuinely compassionate toward all living beings, understanding that every soul is suffering in this material world under the illusion of separateness from Kṛṣṇa. To see their suffering as our own. And to offer, in whatever way we can — through our words, our actions, our example, our resources, our prayers — the greatest gift: Kṛṣṇa consciousness. This is jīva-dayā: not a passive sentiment, but an active, lifelong orientation of the heart toward the wellbeing of all souls.

18. The Light of Pune — Gratitude

I want to thank all of you very much. Pune has become one of the most brilliant, shining lights in our movement — spreading the pure culture of bhakti all over the world. The depth of commitment here, the quality of practice, the spirit of community — it is truly extraordinary. And I owe a very deep and sincere debt of gratitude to each one of you for this.

Some of you have been waiting for many years to make this commitment today. The sincerity that represents — the willingness to prepare, to mature, to be certain before stepping forward — is itself an expression of the seriousness with which you hold this moment. I am so grateful to you for that.

19. Closing Prayers — A Heart Full of Gratitude

I pray — sincerely, with all of my heart — that Śrīla Prabhupāda and all the ācāryas of our Guru-vṛnda, Śrī Śrī Nityānanda-Gauracandra, Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana — the presiding Deities of this most beautiful Govardhan Eco Village — and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra — the presiding Deities of ISKCON NVCC Pune — may shower Their mercy, Their blessings, and Their grace upon each and every one of you.

I pray that They bring you and your families and your loved ones great happiness in Kṛṣṇa consciousness. I pray that They empower you to do wonderful things in Their service — things

that you cannot even fully imagine today, because the Lord's grace is always greater than our capacity to conceive of it.

Thank you very much.

Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (8 March)

1. Purification Mantra (Śuddhi-mantra)

āpavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvāvasthāṁ gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bāhyābhyantaraḥ śuciḥ ||

Source: Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra, incorporated into ISKCON ceremonial liturgy.

2. Ānandamayo 'bhyāsāt — The Soul's Nature of Bliss

ānandamayo 'bhyāsāt

Source: Vedānta-sūtra 1.1.12.

3. Pūrṇam Adah — Completeness of the Absolute

om pūrṇam adah pūrṇam idam pūrṇāt pūrṇam udacyate | pūrṇasya pūrṇam ādāya pūrṇam evāvaśiṣyate ||

Source: Śrī Isopaniṣad, Invocation; Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 5.1.1.

4. Nāma Cintāmaṇiḥ — The Holy Name is Kṛṣṇa Himself

nāma cintāmaṇiḥ kṛṣṇaś caitanya-rasa-vigrahaḥ | pūrṇaḥ śuddho nitya-mukto 'bbinnatvān nāma-nāminoh ||

Source: Padma Purāṇa; cited in Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 17.133.

5. Saṁsāra-dāvānala — The Guru Extinguishes the Fire of Material Life

*saṁsāra-dāvānala-liḍha-loka-trāṇāya kārṇya-ghanāghanatvam | prāptasya kalyāṇa-guṇārṇavasya vande guroḥ śrī-
caraṇāravindam ||*

Source: Gurvaṣṭaka 1, by Śrīla Viśvanātha Cakravartī Ṭhākura.

6. Daivī Hy Eṣā — Material Nature and the Path of Surrender

daivī hy eṣā guṇamayī mama māyā duratyayā | mām eva ye prapadyante māyām etaṁ taranti te ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 7.14.

Historical and Biographical Notes — 8 March

First meeting, Śrīla Prabhupāda & Bhaktisiddhānta	1922 — Calcutta; the commission to spread Caitanya's message in English was given
Last instruction from Guru Mahārāja	1936 — A letter from Jagannātha Purī; same instruction reaffirmed
Senior disciples sent to England & Germany	Early 1930s — First attempt at Western preaching; returned without lasting success
Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta's Bombay base	Early 1930s — Residing near Babulnāth temple; giving lectures there

Śrīla Prabhupāda sails on SS Jaladūta	1965 — 43 years after first receiving the commission
Prabhupāda's books translated	Ongoing — Now in 80+ languages worldwide
Pune Yātrā — Jayapatākā Swami's visit	Recent years — Arrived by ambulance six hours each way despite critical post-stroke condition

Key Terms — 8 March

Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya	Vaiṣṇava disciplic succession from Brahmā through Madhvācārya and Gauḍīya (Caitanya's) line
Harinām-dīkṣā	Initiation into chanting the holy names of the Lord
Anartha	Unwanted, spiritually counterproductive conditioning of the mind and heart
Ānandamaya	Of the nature of bliss; the soul's inherent constitution
Ādhyātmika	Suffering arising from one's own body and mind
Ādhibhautika	Suffering caused by other living beings
Ādhidaivika	Suffering caused by natural forces and higher powers
Samśāra-dāvānala	The burning forest fire of material existence
Nāma cintāmaṇiḥ	The holy name as the wish-fulfilling gem — identical with the Lord Himself
Abhinnatvān nāma-nāminoḥ	The non-difference of the name and the Named — the name IS the Lord
Svayam bhagavān	The original, self-complete Personality of Godhead
Mahā-bhāva	The supreme ecstatic emotional state; the exclusive domain of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī
Dīkṣā-guru	The initiating spiritual master
Śikṣā-guru	The instructing spiritual master
Guru-vṛnda	The assembly or community of spiritual masters
Dāsānudāsa	The servant of the servants — the aspiration of the true Vaiṣṇava
Nāma-ruci	Genuine taste and relish for the holy name
Vaiṣṇava-sevā	Service to and care for the community of devotees
Jīva-dayā	Compassion for all living souls; the impulse to share Kṛṣṇa consciousness
Sādhū-saṅga	The association of holy persons; considered essential for sustaining spiritual faith
Kāryakṣamatā	Conscientious competence; applied Vaiṣṇava character
Ruci	A spontaneous taste or relish; a stage of devotional development
SS Jaladūta	The cargo ship on which Śrīla Prabhupāda sailed from India to the United States in 1965

Govardhan Eco Village (GEV)	ISKCON's sustainable spiritual community in Wada, Palghar district, Maharashtra (~80 km north of Mumbai)
Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī	Presiding Deities of GEV (1st shrine)
Rādhā-Madana-mohana	Presiding Deities of GEV (2nd shrine)
Rādhā-Kuñja-Bihārī	Presiding Deities of ISKCON Pune Camp temple
Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Candra	Presiding Deities of ISKCON NVCC, Pune
Nityānanda-Gauracandra	Lord Nityānanda and Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu

9 March 2026

Initiation Lecture — 9 March 2026

Harinām-dīkṣā Ceremony

1. Opening Invocation — The Maṅgalācaraṇa and Praṇāma Mantras

On behalf of His Divine Grace, His Divya-vigraha-dhārīṇī Śrīla A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda, and in honour of all the worshipful ācāryas of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya, we now commence this harinām-dīkṣā initiation ceremony.

At the opening of every such ceremony we recite the praṇāma mantras — the formal verses of obeisance — to the entire line of spiritual masters. These are the living roots of the tradition we are entering today. We first honour Śrīla Prabhupāda:

*namo om viṣṇu-pādāya kṛṣṇa-preṣṭhāya bhū-tale | śrimate bhaktivedānta-svāmin iti nāmine || namas te sārāsvate deve
gaura-vāṇī-pracārīṇe | nirviśeṣa-śūnyavādī-pāścātya-deśa-tārīṇe ||*

Translation: I offer my respectful obeisances unto His Divine Grace A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda, who is very dear to Lord Kṛṣṇa, having taken shelter at His lotus feet. Our respectful obeisances are unto you, O spiritual master, servant of Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Gosvāmī. You are kindly preaching the message of Lord Caitanyadeva and delivering the Western countries, which are filled with impersonalism and voidism.

(Standard ISKCON praṇāma-mantra to Śrīla Prabhupāda)

We then honour Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura Prabhupāda:

namo om viṣṇu-pādāya kṛṣṇa-preṣṭhāya bhū-tale | śrimate bhaktisiddhānta-sarasvatīti nāmine ||

We then offer praṇāma to Śrīla Gaura-kīśora dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja:

namo gaura-kīśorāya sakṣād-vairāgya-mūrtaye | vipralambha-rasāṇavāya pādāmbujāya te ||

And to Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura:

namo bhaktivinodāya sac-cid-ananda-nāmine | gaura-śakti-svarūpāya rūpānuga-varāya te ||

These praṇāmas are not merely a formal opening. They are a meditation — a conscious act of aligning ourselves with the entire current of grace flowing through the disciplic succession.

2. Welcome to Govardhan Eco Village

I am deeply, profoundly grateful for this opportunity to welcome all of you here. Many of you have travelled long distances to come to this sacred place — Govardhan Eco Village. On behalf of all the Deities — Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana — on behalf of all the devotees, on behalf of all the cows, and on behalf of everyone who calls this extraordinary place home: I welcome you with all my heart.

3. The Yuga-dharma — The Verse That Defines This Age

Every time I lead a gathering such as this, I begin with this celebrated verse from the Bṛhan-nāradiya Purāṇa, which Lord Caitanya's own spiritual master, Śrīla Mādhavendra Purī and the entire Gauḍīya paramparā treasures as the foundational declaration of Kali-yuga's unique gift:

hare nāma hare nāma hare nāmaiva kevalam | kalan nāsty eva nāsty eva nāsty eva gatir anyathā ||

Translation: In this age of Kali-yuga, one should chant the holy name, chant the holy name, chant the holy name of the Lord — there is no other way, no other way, no other way.

(Bṛhan-nāradiya Purāṇa 38.126; cited throughout Gauḍīya literature)

The triple repetition — nāsty eva, nāsty eva, nāsty eva — is deliberate and emphatic. It is not mere poetic flourish. It is the śāstra's own way of making us understand the absolute, total, irreplaceable centrality of harinām in this age. There is no other way. Not partially. Not as an alternative. As the only way.

4. The Nature of Kali-yuga — Degradation and the Greatest Gift

We are in the age of Kali-yuga. It is an age especially recognised for the degradation of humanity — a time when the human population becomes so spiritually impoverished that it is practically impossible to follow the dharma, the religious principles, that were achievable in previous ages. The standards of Satya-yuga, Tretā-yuga, and Dvāpara-yuga — the austerities, the sustained meditation, the elaborate sacrifices — are simply beyond the reach of souls conditioned by the atmosphere of Kali.

And yet — this is a truth I want to deeply impress upon all of you — the great sages and the great ṛṣis actually worship Kali-yuga as the best of all ages. How is this possible? The Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam gives the answer in a verse I will return to shortly. The reason is this: the Supreme Personality of Godhead, knowing fully well that the souls of Kali-yuga truly do not have a chance by their own endeavour, comes to them with the easiest and most powerful means of attaining the ultimate perfection of life — the chanting of the holy names, the yuga-dharma of this age.

The Bhāgavatam declares:

kaler doṣa-nidhe rājann asti hy eko mahān guṇaḥ | kīrtanād eva kṛṣṇasya mukta-saṅgaḥ paraṁ vrajet ||

Translation: My dear king, although Kali-yuga is an ocean of faults and impurities, there is one great quality in this age: simply by chanting the holy names of Kṛṣṇa, one can become free from material association and attain the transcendental kingdom.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 12.3.51)

Kali-yuga is an ocean of faults — doṣa-nidhi, a reservoir of defects. Not a river, not a lake — an ocean. When you stand at the edge of the ocean, what you can see is already staggering. But the faults of Kali-yuga stretch thousands and thousands of miles, practically limitless, in every direction. And somehow or other, all of us are right in the middle of that ocean — drowning — without a raft, without a boat. This is the picture the scripture gives us of our actual situation.

But there is one great quality, one extraordinary exception: kīrtanād eva kṛṣṇasya — simply by chanting the holy names of Kṛṣṇa. Not just happiness. Not just liberation. The perfection of

liberation itself. What was achievable in Satya-yuga only through deep meditation (dhyāna), in Tretā-yuga through performance of yajña, in Dvāpara-yuga through elaborate Deity worship — all of that is accessible simply by chanting the holy names of Lord Hari in Kali-yuga. This is the extraordinary magnanimity of Kali-yuga's hidden gift.

5. The Nature of a True Devotee — Freedom from Envy

To the extent that we are actually, genuinely close to Kṛṣṇa — to the extent we are spiritually illuminated — we become free from envy. And this freedom from envy is the foundation of the Vaiṣṇava's natural quality: parātapīḥ, the quality of feeling others' reality as one's own. We feel happy when we see others happy. We feel suffering when we see others suffering. This is not merely an ethical standard. It is the natural symptom of a purified consciousness.

And the more we taste the supreme happiness of loving devotional service to Kṛṣṇa — bhakti — the more we understand that true happiness is found only in the eternal soul's eternal relationship with the Supreme Soul, Śrī Bhagavān, Paramātmā, Lord Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

Therefore — and this is a very subtle but very important point — when we see people who are enjoying material happiness and prosperity on the physical or intellectual level, but we see no connection with loving service to Kṛṣṇa, it causes pain in the heart of a devotee. Not jealousy. Not judgment. Pain. The pain of seeing someone feasting on what they think is food while actually starving spiritually.

Śrīla Prabhupāda, on many occasions, gave a definition of a Vaiṣṇava that we should all engrave upon our hearts: a Vaiṣṇava is one who does not have envy. And to the degree we do not have envy — we have love. And that love is expressed outwardly as compassion.

6. Navadvīpa Before the Appearance — The Suffering of the Saints

The Caitanya-bhāgavata of Vṛndāvana dāsa Ṭhākura describes in extraordinary detail the condition of the world — and specifically of Navadvīpa — just prior to the appearance of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu.

Navadvīpa was a city of astonishing prosperity and learning. There was so much opulence that people gathered there from all directions. And in that culture, the most prestigious form of wealth was not money or property — it was knowledge. The most celebrated individuals were the most learned scholars, professors, and empowered students. There was food for everyone, comfortable living for everyone, festivals constantly. It was, in many ways, like a heavenly planet on earth.

And yet — the great Vaiṣṇavas living there, the eternal associates of the Lord: Ādvaita Ācārya, Śācīmātā, Śrī Vāsu, Śrī Rāma, Śrī Nidhi, Śrī Pati, Murāri Gupta — these devotees were experiencing deep, deep pain. Why? Because they saw vast multitudes of people celebrating so many festivals based on utterly meaningless occasions, completely disconnected from the soul's relationship with God, thinking they were thoroughly happy when in fact they were spiritually starving.

This is the extraordinary consciousness of a pāvana-snāva Vaiṣṇava — a purified devotee. Another person's suffering is my suffering. Another person's happiness is my happiness. But the Vaiṣṇavas of Navadvīpa were suffering seeing other people's misconception of happiness.

People were thinking they were happy — and the devotees were suffering seeing them think so. Only when we realise we are not the body and mind — that we are the eternal soul — do we begin to feel for the souls of others rather than merely their bodies.

This is why Kṛṣṇa tells Arjuna at the very beginning of the Bhagavad-gītā: 'You can understand these teachings because you are free from envy.' And this is why Śukadeva Gosvāmī tells King Parīkṣit the same.

7. Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu — The Most Magnanimous Incarnation

Only once in a day of Brahmā — a cosmic timespan of approximately 4.32 billion years — does Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu appear on this earth planet. And why does He come?

The answer is given in the exquisite understanding revealed through the Caitanya-caritāmṛta: rādhā-bhāva-dyuti-suvalitaṁ naumi kṛṣṇa-svarūpam. Kṛṣṇa in Goloka Vṛndāvana — perfect, omniscient, the source of all incarnations, the ultimate reality — wants to understand the nature of Śrī Rādhā's love. He wants to know: what is it about Himself that gives Her such immeasurable happiness? What is the sweetness She tastes in Her love for Him, and what is the happiness She experiences when She tastes the sweetness of His love?

Kṛṣṇa knows everything — past, present, and future, every living entity in all material and spiritual worlds. There is nothing of which He is not completely conscious. But this is one principle which, by His own sweet free will, He wishes to experience from the inside.

Because Kṛṣṇa is bhaktavatsala — deeply, intimately, overwhelmingly dear to His devotees, and His devotees are supremely dear to Him. And of all devotees, Śrī Rādhā is His hlādinī-śakti — the supreme reservoir of all love, the treasured potency of the Lord.

Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu is Kṛṣṇa who has come to this earth planet with the mahā-bhāva — the supreme ecstatic state — of Śrī Rādhā, and the resplendent golden complexion of Śrī Rādhā, to experience that love Himself. And by His own supreme mercy — paramahaprabhu-nyāya — He simultaneously comes as the yuga-avatāra, to give the yuga-dharma of harinām:

namo mahā-vadānyāya kṛṣṇa-prema-pradāya te | kṛṣṇāya kṛṣṇa-caitanya-nāmne gaura-tviṣe namaḥ ||

Translation: I offer my respectful obeisances unto the Supreme Lord Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, who is more magnanimous than any other avatāra, even Kṛṣṇa Himself, because He is bestowing freely what no one else has ever given — pure love of Kṛṣṇa.

(Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 19.53; composed by Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī)

Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī — who is Rūpa Mañjarī in Goloka Vṛndāvana, the intimate loving confidential maidservant of Lalitā Sakhī in the service of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī — knows more intimately than almost anyone what is most precious in all of existence. And he is declaring that of all incarnations,

Lord Caitanya is the most magnanimous, the most merciful. Because He is giving, freely — what no other incarnation has given so generously: the love of Śrī Rādhā and the love of the residents of Goloka Vṛndāvana.

8. The Garland of Holy Names — Kṛṣṇa-nāma and Kṛṣṇa-prīti

How does Lord Caitanya give that love? The answer is beautiful and simple. Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī's verse captures it: Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu came to put a garland around the whole world. And what is that garland? It is woven with the flowers of Kṛṣṇa's holy names — saṅkīrtana — and ecstatic love for Kṛṣṇa. He gives Kṛṣṇa-prīti through Kṛṣṇa-nāma.

Kavirāja Gosvāmī tells us that when Mahāprabhu was in Navadvīpa — after coming from Gayā, having been initiated by Śrī Īśvarapurī, and having received the instruction to establish the saṅkīrtana movement — he described himself at the time of the first public harinām procession to the Kāzī's house as bringing down a massive monsoon rainstorm of Kṛṣṇa-prīti through Kṛṣṇa-nāma. He literally declared this just before the kīrtana began.

It began humbly enough — in the house of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura, and in his own home, the Yoga-pīṭha, sometimes called the Candrasekhara-bhavana. Mahāprabhu held kīrtanas with His eternal associates and most intimate devotees.

9. The Kāzī's Opposition — Saṅkīrtana Tested by Power

But very quickly, powerful opposition arose. So many people were deeply envious — criticising, complaining, and not merely complaining but threatening. They threatened to go to the Kāzī — the Muslim magistrate, the prevailing government authority — so that he would forcibly stop the kīrtana. They threatened to pick up the entire household of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura and throw it into the Gaṅgā along with all the devotees, to be rid of them forever.

And these were not insignificant voices. These were very influential brāhmaṇas speaking. The opposition was real and dangerous.

But among those who came to the kīrtanas, there were also the most humble souls — simple brāhmaṇas, shopkeepers, simple workers, farmers. They felt themselves utterly unworthy to be present in those kīrtanas. But every morning they would come and offer whatever little they had to Lord Caitanya — some rice, a piece of maṇḍī, a little milk. And Lord Caitanya — seeing their deep, genuine humility — told them: 'You chant these names of Kṛṣṇa.' He gave them the Mahā-mantra. He said: 'Chant when you are walking, when you are sitting, when you are lying down, when you are working, when you are eating, when you are with your family. Just chant these holy names. And when you are with your family or with your friends, play instruments and sing the holy names of the Lord. Always remember Kṛṣṇa.'

Mahāprabhu declared this chanting of the holy names to be the param vijayate — para-upakāra — the prime benediction for all of humanity. And those simple souls did exactly that. They were at their shops, walking down the streets, in their homes with their families — chanting.

And then the Kāzī heard about it and saw it. He was enraged. He sent his soldiers. Wherever there was the sound of a mṛdaṅga, wherever there was any kind of chanting, they would beat the chanters, plunder their homes, and imprison them. He warned: 'If you stop now, I will not punish you so severely. But if you continue—' He was the prevailing government authority. He was deeply oppressive.

The people came to Lord Caitanya in desperation: 'We want to leave this place. We will go somewhere else. We cannot disobey your instruction — but we cannot do it here. It is too dangerous. We have families, we have friends.'

Lord Caitanya said: 'Go back and chant.' He said: 'Today I will lead the chanting. Let us see what anyone does to Me. Bring torches and come tonight.'

And that very historic harinām procession went forth — Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu in the streets with the mṛdaṅgas and karatālas, Lord Nityānanda Prabhu beside Him, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura, Haridāsa Ṭhākura dancing, Bhakṣīśvara Paṇḍita, Murāri Gupta, Puṇḍarīka Vidyānidhi — all of Kola-veśa, all the koṭi Vaiṣṇavas were singing and dancing. Hundreds and thousands of torches illuminated the night. The most glorious processional demonstration of saṅkīrtana the world had ever seen.

10. Caitanya Mahāprabhu's Departure — South Indian Pilgrimage

But after some time, to reach the whole world, Lord Caitanya left home. He went to Katwa and accepted sannyāsa from Keśava Bhārati Mahārāja. From Katwa, Nityānanda Prabhu led Lord Caitanya to Śāntipura, where mother Śacī and all the devotees — whose lives had been scorched by the flames of separation — were rescued once more by the presence of Śrī Caitanya. But now instead of Viśvambhara — with his long hair and his beautiful ornaments and garlands — it was Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya: shaved head, simple sannyāsī robes, carrying only a kamaṇḍalu and a daṇḍa.

Mother Śacī prayed to Lord Caitanya that if He went to Vṛndāvana, she would never receive news of Him and would not be able to live. She said: 'Go and make Your home in Purī, where the same Kṛṣṇa lives in the form of Jagannātha, and all Your devotees can come to visit You, and I will always be hearing messages of Your well-being.' The power of a devotee's love — Lord Caitanya put aside His own cherished aspiration to go to Vṛndāvana to honour the love of His mother. And they went to Purī.

Just after a few months in Purī, Lord Caitanya Mahāprabhu proclaimed to His associates: 'I am going on a pilgrimage to the holy places of South India. I am going to search for my brother who left home so long ago.' But Kavirāja Gosvāmī describes this was His external pretext — His true

spirit was to spread the saṅkīrtana movement to everyone, anyone, without consideration of who they were, during His pilgrimage through South India.

He took only one new devotee as a companion — Kṛṣṇadāsa — because he did not want to expose his personal associates to the severe austerities he would be performing. He walked barefoot through the length and breadth of South India. He did not take any of his intimate companions.

And how did he spread Kṛṣṇa consciousness? Simply by chanting. Whoever he met, he would induce them to chant. And if anybody accepted his invitation to chant with him — Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu, who is svayam-bhagavān, the source of all incarnations — he would embrace that person. He would offer them all respect. He would thank them with tears of compassion.

11. The South Indian Pilgrimage — Sacred Places Visited

I feel particular joy in the presence of so many of you who have come from South India. How your land and your forefathers and mothers were recipients of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu's mercy! He visited the most glorious temples and sacred sites of the South: Śrī Kūrmakṣetra — Āchalānanda — the sacred Narasiṃha temple at Jyāḍa Narasiṃha — Śrī Śailam — Kāñcīpuram — Tirupati — Śrī Raṅgam (where He stayed for four months; there are several wonderful chapters describing His līlās there) — Madurai — Rāmeśvaram — Kanyākumārī — Thiruvananthapuram (Śrī Ananta Padmanābha) — Gokarna — Udupi — and then to Paṇḍharpur (via Nāsik).

He visited the most glorious temples of Lord Rāmacandra, Viṣṇu, Nārāyaṇa, Varāha, and Narasiṃha. And He is the source of all these incarnations. And yet He was begging people to take the name of Kṛṣṇa.

He followed the Godāvarī River all the way from Nāsik back to Pañcavaṭī. And of course, further along that river — at its banks — occurred what is perhaps the most intimate and elevated of all philosophical discussions in all our literature: when Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu spoke with Śrī Rāmānanda Rāya on the banks of the Godāvarī. There He revealed, step by step, the ascending levels of spiritual realisation, culminating in the mādhyura-rasa — the sweet love of the Gopīs — and ultimately the supreme love of Śrī Rādhā Herself, whom Rāmānanda Rāya identified as higher even than the Gopīs.

And in that South Indian tour, Lord Caitanya proceeded also to meet Rāmānanda Rāya a second time at Jagannātha Purī, and their conversation about the nature of the highest love became the philosophical foundation of the entire Gauḍīya tradition.

12. The Philosophy of the Supreme Dharma

The Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam declares the supreme principle — sa vai puṁsām paro dharmah:

sa vai puṁsām paro dharmo yato bhaktir adbokṣaje | abaitukey apratibatā yayātmā suprasīdati ||

Translation: The supreme occupation [dharma] for all humanity is that by which men can attain to loving devotional service unto the transcendent Lord. Such devotional service must be unmotivated and uninterrupted to completely satisfy the self.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.6)

And Sanātana Gosvāmī, in the Bṛhad-bhāgavatāmṛta, describes an evolution of pure, unalloyed, unmotivated, uninterrupted loving service. There is the level of Prahlaḍa Mahārāja and Hanumān. There is the level of the Yadus. The whole Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam is filled with devotees who demonstrate this unmotivated, uninterrupted loving service — but it culminates in the intimate loving rāsas of Vṛndāvana, where Kṛṣṇa is so overwhelmed by love that by His own free will, He gives us the eternal experience of loving Kṛṣṇa as our purest friend, as a parent, as a child — and in the culmination, the mādhyura-rasa, the love of the Gopīs, who with the purest hearts love Kṛṣṇa solely for His happiness.

And Rāmānanda Rāya describes, upon Lord Caitanya's request, that even higher than the Gopīs is the love of the Supreme Gopī — Śrī Rādhā. And Lord Caitanya is Kṛṣṇa in the mood of that Rādhā — giving that very love to all of us. How rare. How extraordinary. How special.

13. Jīva Gosvāmī — The Rasācārya

Jīva Gosvāmī has presented all of this in the most comprehensive, authorised, and systematic philosophical and spiritual science ever compiled. He is the Rasācārya — the master of transcendental rasa. He describes the culmination of all philosophy, all spiritual science, all culture — and that culmination is pure, simple, unmotivated love. This includes all other paths and transcends them. It is the ocean into which all rivers of spiritual seeking ultimately flow.

14. The 1922 Commission — The Ocean Within a Simple Sentence

In 1922, when Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura first met the young Abhay Caran De — later to become Śrīla Prabhupāda — he told him: 'You are an educated young man. Take the message of Lord Caitanya in the English language to the Western world.'

It sounds like a simple instruction. But everything we have been discussing today — and limitlessly more — is contained within that one sentence. What is Lord Caitanya's teaching? It is the highest teaching made accessible to the lowest people. It is the bottomless, shoreless ocean of spiritual love, made available through the most simple and direct means: the pure chanting of the holy names.

And simply by purely chanting the holy names, by developing Kṛṣṇa-faith — śraddhā — that love manifests from our hearts. Paraṁ vijayate — all glory to the holy name.

But to continue this practice, it is very important that we have śraddhā — strong, living faith. And faith comes by hearing, in the association of devotees who themselves have faith. According to our capacity, we should sincerely study Śrīla Prabhupāda's books. He gave his heart — his very life — to us in those books. We should share this message with each other through hari-kathā, through

Bhagavad-gītā class, through Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam class, through simply discussing Kṛṣṇa with one another. And we must engage in beautiful temple worship — but all transcendental bhakti literature is filled with Kṛṣṇa's names. With every offering to the Deities, we offer it with Kṛṣṇa's names. Harinām is integral to every single aspect of our devotional life.

15. Śrīla Prabhupāda's Poem — A Beggar's Prayer

Śrīla Prabhupāda, sailing alone to America on the SS Jaladūta in 1965, was tasting the supreme sweetness of executing the order of his Guru Mahārāja — taking this message of love of God, hari-nāma, to the whole world. He wanted us — each and every one of us — to have that same experience.

He appealed to us as an insignificant beggar. In his beautiful poem 'Markine Bhāgavata-dharma' — written on board the Jaladūta on 18 September 1965, as he arrived in Boston — he wrote to Kṛṣṇa, saying he was an insignificant beggar. He begged Kṛṣṇa: 'Please help me. Please help me to carry out the mission of my Guru Mahārāja — to spread Kṛṣṇa consciousness all over the world.'

And it begins with ourselves — with our families, within the communities around our temples, within the communities gathered around the chanting of the holy names.

16. The Commitment — Duty and Gratitude

So today we are making a commitment. It is a commitment of duty — yes. But it is far more than that. It is a commitment of gratitude. Because what our hearts are really chanting when they are in the right spirit is: 'We are chanting because we are grateful to have received this mercy.' We are chanting a minimum of sixteen rounds of the Mahā-mantra each day — not to fulfil a quota, not out of fear — but to reciprocate with gratitude for what we are receiving. And a grateful heart is a heart that can receive Kṛṣṇa-prīti. An ungrateful heart — however many rounds we chant — will always find Kṛṣṇa-prīti remaining at a distance.

So we should chant. And we should chant with gratitude. As an expression of that gratitude, we perform the duty of chanting as much as possible — with our fullest attention, regularly, with our minds, with our intellect, with our hearts, and with our very souls, offered to Kṛṣṇa.

17. Unity in Diversity — The Principle of the Sampradāya

Śrīla Prabhupāda gave us the profound principle of unity in diversity. We are united on the higher principle — what will please Śrīla Prabhupāda and our gurus — and we unite, even with our differences. Our differences are not obstacles. They are the very expression of the richness of this tradition when held together by that higher principle.

And alongside this comes the principle of tapasyā — the purifying austerity of spiritual life. The Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam declares:

tapo divyaṁ putrakā yena sattvaṁ | śuddhyed yasmād brahma-saukhyam tv anantam ||

Translation: My dear sons, you should therefore perform austerity — divine austerity — by which one's existence is purified, and from which comes transcendental, unlimited bliss.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 5.5.1)

Just bathing in ice-cold water is a very good tapasya. And cooking in 42-degree Celsius heat, as they do here at GEV every day, is a very big tapasya. But the greatest tapasya — the one that pleases our guru, the one that draws Kṛṣṇa most powerfully — is this: to honour and respect each other as Vaiṣṇavas and to live by the higher principle of unity in diversity for the purpose of sharing Kṛṣṇa consciousness.

18. Lord Caitanya Walked and Śrīla Prabhupāda Circled the Globe

Think about it. Lord Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — He did not wear shoes. He walked barefoot through forests, through rivers, through the scorching South Indian roads, all the way down to Kanyākumārī — and back — over more than two years of continuous pilgrimage. Nothing but Kṛṣṇa-nāma and Kṛṣṇa-prīti. Then He sent the Six Gosvāmīs to Vṛndāvana to create a culture where that love would be established and spread throughout the world. And our ācāryas developed that culture through their bhakti, through their temples, through their extraordinary writings.

Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura began sending the teachings of Lord Caitanya and the love of Vṛndāvana to the world. Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura started an institution for that purpose, establishing 64 temples in India and sending devotees to England and Germany. And then our Śrīla Prabhupāda — following Lord Caitanya who walked for two years through all the Eastern, Southern, and Western provinces of India — circled the entire globe twelve times carrying this message.

19. The Preciousness of Every Devotee

When Śrīla Prabhupāda would hear of one devotee criticising another, he would sometimes say with great emotion: 'I have sacrificed buckets of my own personal blood to bring each individual devotee to this movement.' And those who were most senior in our Sampradāya — Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura Prabhupāda — said the same. So how important is each devotee? How important is this message? How valuable is this gift we are receiving?

Here is the truth about what this initiation is: It is not just taking some promises and receiving a new name. It is committing ourselves to this spirit — to this entire lineage of love, mercy, and compassion that flows from the eternal world of Goloka Vṛndāvana down into this present moment.

20. Closing Gratitude and Prayers

I thank all of you. I thank you very much. In this age of Kali, with so many alternatives pulling in every direction — you are coming forward to commit your lives. I am deeply, deeply, deeply grateful to each and every one of you.

And I sincerely pray that Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Vṛndāvana-Bihārī and Śrī Śrī Rādhā-Madana-mohana — the presiding Deities of this most beautiful Govardhan Eco Village — may shower Their mercy, Their blessings, and Their grace upon you. I share this prayer with you: that They, along with all of our ācāryas, bestow supreme happiness upon you and your loved ones, and empower you to truly do wonderful things in Their service.

Thank you very much.

Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (9 March)

1. Praṇāma Mantra to Śrīla Prabhupāda

*namo om viṣṇu-pādāya kṛṣṇa-preṣṭhāya bhū-tale | śrimate bhaktivedānta-svāmin iti nāmine || namas te sārāsvate deve
gaura-vāṇi-pracārīṇe | nirviṣeṣa-śūnyavādi-pāścātya-deśa-tarīṇe ||*

Source: Standard ISKCON praṇāma-mantra to Śrīla Prabhupāda.

2. Praṇāma to Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura

namo om viṣṇu-pādāya kṛṣṇa-preṣṭhāya bhū-tale | śrimate bhaktisiddhānta-sarasvatīti nāmine ||

Source: Standard ISKCON praṇāma-mantra to Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta.

3. Praṇāma to Śrīla Gaura-kiśora dāsa Bābājī

namo gaura-kiśorāya śakṣād-vairāgya-mūrtaye | vipralambha-rasāṇavāya pādāmbujāya te ||

Source: Traditional Gauḍīya praṇāma to Śrīla Gaura-kiśora dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja.

4. Praṇāma to Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura

namo bhaktivinodāya sac-cid-ananda-nāmine | gaura-śakti-svarūpāya rūpānuga-varāya te ||

Source: Traditional Gauḍīya praṇāma to Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura.

5. The Yuga-dharma Verse — Hare Nāma Kevalam

hare nāma hare nāma hare nāmaiva kevalam | kalam nāsty eva nāsty eva nāsty eva gatir anyathā ||

Source: Br̥han-nāradya Purāṇa 38.126.

6. The Treasure of Kali-yuga

kaler doṣa-nidhe rājann asti hy eko mahān guṇaḥ | kīrtanād eva kṛṣṇasya mukta-saṅgaḥ paraṁ vrajet ||

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 12.3.51.

7. Rūpa Gosvāmī's Verse on Lord Caitanya's Magnanimity

namo mahā-vadānyāya kṛṣṇa-prema-pradāya te | kṛṣṇāya kṛṣṇa-caitanya-nāme gaura-tviṣe namaḥ ||

Source: Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 19.53; composed by Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī.

8. The Supreme Dharma

sa vai puṁsāṁ paro dharmo yato bhaktir adhokeṣaje | abaituky apratibatā yayātmā suprasīdati ||

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.6.

9. Divine Austerity — The Purpose of Tapasyā

tapo dīvyam putrakā yena sattvam śuddhyed | yasmād brahma-saukhyam tv anantam ||

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 5.5.1 (Rṣabhadeva's instructions to His sons).

Key People, Places, and Terms — 9 March

Vṛndāvana dāsa Ṭhākura	Author of Caitanya-bhāgavata; described Navadvīpa before Mahāprabhu's appearance
Ādvaita Ācārya	One of the Pañca-tattva; prayed intensely for Lord Caitanya's descent
Śacīmātā	Mother of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; her request redirected Him from Vṛndāvana to Purī
Murāri Gupta	An eternal associate of Lord Caitanya; present in the first saṅkīrtana procession
Puṇḍarīka Vidyānidhi	Disciple of Mādhavendra Purī; an eternal associate of the Lord
Haridāsa Ṭhākura	'Nāmācārya'; the greatest exemplar of chanting the holy names
Kavirāja Gosvāmī	Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja Gosvāmī; author of Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta
Rāmānanda Rāya	Governor of Vidyānagara; had the most intimate philosophical conversation with Lord Caitanya on the banks of the Godāvarī
Jīva Gosvāmī	Called Rasācārya; presented the complete philosophical system of Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇavism in the Ṣaṭ Sandarbhas
Kāzī	The Muslim magistrate of Navadvīpa who tried to suppress the saṅkīrtana movement
Yoga-pīṭha	Lord Caitanya's birthplace and home in Navadvīpa
Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura	Eternal associate of Lord Caitanya; the saṅkīrtana movement began in his courtyard
Keśava Bhāratī Mahārāja	The sannyāsa-guru from whom Lord Caitanya accepted the renounced order at Katwa
Hlādinī-śakti	The internal pleasure potency of the Lord; personified as Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī
Rādhā-bhāva-dyuti-suvalītam	'Adorned with the mood and the lustre of Śrī Rādhā' — describing Lord Caitanya's nature
Yuga-avatāra	The incarnation of the Lord who appears in each age to give the appropriate dharma for that age
Doṣa-nidhi	Ocean of faults; the Bhāgavatam's description of Kali-yuga
Markine Bhāgavata-dharma	Śrīla Prabhupāda's poem written on the Jaladūta on 18 September 1965 upon arrival in Boston
Rūpa Mañjarī	The identity of Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī in Goloka Vṛndāvana — intimate maidservant of Śrī Rādhā
GEV	Govardhan Eco Village, Wada, Palghar district, ~80 km north of Mumbai

10 March 2026

Initiation Lecture — 10 March 2026

Harinām-dīkṣā Ceremony

1. Opening Invocation — The Spirit of Praṇāma

On behalf of His Divine Grace, Śrīla A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda, and in honour of all the worshipful ācāryas of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya, we now begin today's hadinām-dīkṣā initiation ceremony.

During these initiation ceremonies, Śrīla Prabhupāda had us chant the Maṅgala-caraṇa — the auspicious opening prayers. Then we honour and worship our Guru-paramparā. And Śrīla Prabhupāda translated the Sanskrit word nāmā — not merely as a respectful salutation, not merely as praṇāma — but as surrender. This distinction matters enormously. When we offer nāmā, we are not simply performing a polite bow. We are making an act of surrender. We are offering ourselves. And that is the very basis of our entire teaching.

2. The Foundation — Total Surrender to Kṛṣṇa

The very basis of all our teachings is to have śraddhā — complete, unwavering faith — in Kṛṣṇa's words. And the most complete expression of that faith is surrender. Kṛṣṇa gives this instruction in the final, most essential verse of the Bhagavad-gītā:

sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇaṁ vraja | ahaṁ tvāṁ sarva-pāpebhyo mokṣayiṣyāmi mā śucaḥ ||

Translation: Abandon all varieties of religion and just surrender unto Me. I shall deliver you from all sinful reactions. Do not fear.

(Bhagavad-gītā 18.66)

If we just abandon all other lower principles and surrender to Kṛṣṇa, He promises not only to protect us but to deliver us from all our previous karmas. Every accumulated burden of every action performed in every previous lifetime — He takes it all. This is the breathtaking completeness of śaraṇāgati, surrender.

And prior to this final verse, Kṛṣṇa gives us the practical formula of surrender, telling us:

man-manā bhava mad-bhākto mad-yājī mām namaskuru | mām evaiṣyasi yuktvaivam ātmānaṁ mat-parīyaṇaḥ ||

Translation: Always think of Me, become My devotee, worship Me, and offer your homage unto Me. Thus you will come to Me without fail. I promise you this, because you are My very dear friend.

(Bhagavad-gītā 18.65)

Always think of Me. Become My devotee. Worship Me. Offer your homage to Me. In this way, you will come to Me without fail. And Kṛṣṇa says: 'I promise you this — because you are My

devotee.' This is Kṛṣṇa's personal promise. Not a general statement, not a universal declaration — a personal promise, addressed to every sincere devotee who takes shelter.

3. The Nine Processes of Devotional Service

If we follow this path of bhakti, the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam describes nine integral processes of devotional service:

śravaṇaṁ kīrtanaṁ viṣṇoḥ smaraṇaṁ pāda-sevanam | arcanam vandanam dāsyam sakhyam ātma-nivedanam ||

Translation: Hearing and chanting about the transcendental holy name, form, qualities, paraphernalia, and pastimes of Lord Viṣṇu; remembering them; serving the lotus feet of the Lord; offering the Lord respectful worship with sixteen types of paraphernalia; offering prayers to the Lord; becoming His servant; considering the Lord one's best friend; and surrendering everything unto Him — these nine processes are accepted as pure devotional service.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 7.5.23)

These nine — beginning with śravaṇa (hearing about Kṛṣṇa, His teachings, His pastimes, His qualities, His devotees), then kīrtana (chanting His glories, speaking about Him, chanting His holy names), then smaraṇa (remembering) — constitute the practical path by which, while living within this world, we can always remember Kṛṣṇa. By practising any one of these nine processes sincerely, the power of remembering Kṛṣṇa — which is supremely, infinitely pure — will transform and purify us completely.

4. The Power of Kṛṣṇa Over Māyā — The Ocean and the Hoofprint

Māyā is very strong. Within this material world, so many people are profoundly entrapped within the influences of māyā — material illusion. But there is something to understand clearly: Kṛṣṇa is the controller of Māyā. The Bhagavad-gītā declares:

daivi hy eṣa guṇamayī mama māyā duratyayā | mām eva ye prapadyante māyām etaṁ taranti te ||

Translation: This divine energy of Mine, consisting of the three modes of material nature, is difficult to overcome. But those who have surrendered unto Me can easily cross beyond it.

(Bhagavad-gītā 7.14)

When we take shelter of Kṛṣṇa alone — when we truly surrender — Kṛṣṇa delivers us from the powers of Māyā. We have no power on our own. When we are disconnected from Kṛṣṇa, all we have is our own limited abilities — and those very abilities are completely captured by Māyā. How can we get out of Māyā when everything we have to work with is already under Māyā's spell? But when Kṛṣṇa intervenes, He easily delivers us.

The Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam describes it beautifully:

*samāsṛitā ye pada-pallava-plavaṇaṁ mahat-padaṁ puṇya-yaśo murāreḥ | bhavāmbudhir vatsa-padaṁ paraṁ padaṁ
padaṁ padaṁ yad vipadaṁ na teṣāṁ ||*

Translation: For those who have accepted the boat of the lotus feet of the Lord, who is the shelter of the cosmic manifestation and is famous as Murāri, the enemy of the Mura

demon, the ocean of the material world is like the water contained in a calf's hoofprint. Their goal is *Vaikuṇṭha*, the place where there are no material miseries, not this place where there is danger at every step.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.14.58)

This vast material energy — this ocean of *māyā* that stretches in all directions, none of us able to swim across it alone — becomes, by *Kṛṣṇa*'s grace, the quantity of water contained in the hoofprint of a calf. That is *Kṛṣṇa*'s power. *Kṛṣṇa* can make the water in a hoofprint into an ocean, or the water of an ocean into a hoofprint. Such is the absolute sovereignty of the Lord.

And therefore the idea of *śaraṇāgati* — taking shelter, true surrender — is the eternal principle: *nityaṁ nityānāṁ cetanaś cetanānāṁ* — we are eternally dependent on the Supreme Lord. We are eternally subordinate, eternally dependent on *Kṛṣṇa*'s mercy. This is not a weakness. It is our constitutional nature. And recognising it is not defeat — it is liberation.

5. The Mahā-mantra — 32 Syllables, 16 Words, 3 Names, One Prayer

When Śrīla Prabhupāda taught us to chant the Hare *Kṛṣṇa* Mahā-mantra, he was teaching us the very spirit, the essential soul, of the *Bhagavad-gītā*, the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, and the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* — all distilled into sixteen names.

From a purely mathematical perspective, the Mahā-mantra is 32 syllables, 16 words, and 3 names of God. But from the perspective of *bhakti* — what is our mood when we chant it? What is our feeling? What is our purpose?

Śrīla Prabhupāda describes: we should chant the holy names as a prayer — the prayer of a devotee calling out to the Lord: 'My dear *Rādhā*, the energy of the Lord — my dear Hare. My dear *Kṛṣṇa*, all-attractive Supreme. My dear *Rāma*, reservoir of all pleasure. Please allow me to engage in Your loving devotional service.'

Throughout the world, in the name of religion, dharma, people approach God for favours. When we are in difficulty, we want God to resolve our difficulties. When we really want something, we want God to give it to us. When we are really happy, we usually forget God entirely — because that is the nature of conditioned life in this world.

But this Mahā-mantra is teaching something profoundly different: 'My Lord — how can I please You? How can I serve You?' It is not a petition. It is an offering. It is the turning of the entire self toward *Kṛṣṇa*, not to extract but to give.

6. The Purification Verse — In All Situations of Life

This ceremony opens, as always, with the great purification verse:

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvāvasthām gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bahyaḥ śuciḥ ||

(Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra)

It is describing: whether we are pure or not pure — and the next part is so important — 'even while passing through all the various conditions of life.' The ups, the downs. The honour and the dishonour. Happiness and distress. Health and disease. Celebrations and tragedies. Youth and old age. Peace and war. Birth and death. Whatever the situation may be — if we just take shelter of Kṛṣṇa, if we just remember Kṛṣṇa, then we become purified both within and without.

And when the heart becomes pure, we realise our natural constitutional position — that we are eternally servants of Kṛṣṇa. And there is only one kind of service that actually pleases Kṛṣṇa: service offered with love. Just doing what we are told is a type of service that can help us become more purified. But when we are sincerely trying to please Kṛṣṇa by our devotion, by our love — by speaking what is pleasing to Kṛṣṇa, by thinking what is pleasing to Kṛṣṇa, by doing what is pleasing to Kṛṣṇa — that is the true nature of this path, and the only true goal of life.

7. How to Chant — Like a Baby Calling Its Mother

Śrīla Prabhupāda describes it with the most tender analogy: the Mahā-mantra should be chanted like a little baby child who, at a time of great need, with its whole being — with everything that small baby has — cries out for its mother. Total helplessness. Total dependence. Total love. That is how we should chant the holy names.

This is not something we can do artificially, by imitation or performance. But we cultivate that mood by sincerely trying to live in the mood of being the servant of the servant of the servant — for Kṛṣṇa's pleasure. As strictly as possible we take shelter of the holy names. We take shelter of Kṛṣṇa's pastimes, Kṛṣṇa's mercy. And we take shelter of Kṛṣṇa in the form of the Deity.

8. The Deity — Kṛṣṇa's Mercy in Visible Form

Kṛṣṇa is still supremely kind to us. We cannot, in our present conditioned state, see the universal form of the Lord. We cannot see Kṛṣṇa playing His flute in Vṛndāvana with His cowherd friends. But Kṛṣṇa appears in the form of the Deity — precisely so that with faith, with bhāva, with genuine devotion, we can see Him. We can humble ourselves before Him. We can serve Him — dance for Him, sing for Him, cook for Him, offer our tears for Him, build temples for Him, create entire communities centred around Him.

Kṛṣṇa appears in the Deity form for this very reason: to help us, in the conditioned state, to find the supreme joy in His shelter. Because what is the shelter of God? It is to come into the light of God's limitless, intimate love. Taking shelter of the Lord at the beginning stages may feel like simply holding on somehow. But actually, the full shelter of the Lord is the Lord's love. And bhakti is about always remembering Kṛṣṇa, never forgetting Kṛṣṇa — in a mood of perpetual, tender, grateful surrender.

As much as possible, we cultivate the consciousness where whatever we do, whatever we say, whatever we think — we try to do it in such a way that Kṛṣṇa is pleased. And we are fallen. We

should not be discouraged by our fallen condition. We should not be discouraged by our wavering mind or our imperfections. But we should honestly, earnestly, and sincerely strive to improve ourselves for the pleasure of Kṛṣṇa.

And Kṛṣṇa dwells within the heart of those who love Him — within our gurus. When we sincerely try to please them, Kṛṣṇa is pleased.

9. Meditating on the Paramparā — Are We Really Surrendered?

We begin with the Vandanā — invoking prayers of respect, gratitude, and surrender to the most eminent ācāryas in our disciplic succession. We begin with our gurus — our dīkṣā-guru, our śikṣā-gurus — and all those Vaiṣṇavas who are helping us in our spiritual life:

om ajñāna-timirāndhasya jñānāñjana-śalākayā | cakṣur unmilitam yena tasmai śrī-gurave namaḥ ||
(Traditional guru-vandanā)

The verse continues: 'sarvopakāriṇe śrī-gurave' — to the dīkṣā-guru, śikṣā-guru, and all Vaiṣṇavas who are helping us.' It's not just a song we recite. Are we really meditating on what we recite? Are we really prepared in our life to live accordingly?

10. Śrīla Prabhupāda — The Ocean Within a Single Instruction

Śrīla Prabhupāda received the order of his Guru Mahārāja in 1922, and again in 1936 — the first instruction and the last instruction he ever received from Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura were identically the same: 'Take the message of Lord Caitanya in the English language to the Western world.'

Within the seed of that instruction is the profound, complete teaching of Lord Caitanya — everything. Just as Vyāsadeva compiled the four Vedas, the Upaniṣads, the Itihāsas, the Smṛtis, the Mahābhārata — and still, by Kṛṣṇa's arrangement, there was something incomplete, something missing in his heart. It was Nārada Muni who advised him: take all the knowledge of all the Vedic literatures and all spiritual truths throughout all existence for all time — and put the purest essence into one book. A book with no sub-religious principles. Only the highest principle: pure, ecstatic love for God. And that book was the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam.

Kṛṣṇa in the spiritual world of Goloka — suffused with the mahā-bhāva, the supreme ecstatic love of Śrī Rādhā — descended into this world as Lord Caitanya. And Lord Caitanya taught the pure message of the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam. How to realise the essence of the Bhāgavatam? By following in the footsteps of all the great souls we read about therein — mahājano yena gataḥ sa panthāḥ — and it all culminates with the residents of Vṛndāvana, the Gopīs, and Śrī Rādhā.

And Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Mahāprabhu Himself wrote only eight verses in His entire life — the Śikṣāṣṭaka — the eight verses of instruction. He spoke teachings for others to write and expand upon. But He wrote these eight himself — especially as the glorification of Kṛṣṇa's holy names, and the spirit and mood of surrender in which we should learn to take Kṛṣṇa's name:

paraṁ vijayate śrī-kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtanam
(Śikṣaṣṭaka 1 — Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; cited in Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Antya-līlā 20.12)

'All glory to the Śrī-Kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana!' — this is the beginning and the summit of Mahāprabhu's teaching. The whole Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, the Caitanya-caritāmṛta, the Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, all the great literatures of Rūpa Gosvāmī, Sanātana Gosvāmī, Jīva Gosvāmī, Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura, Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura — all of it is within the seed of that one instruction: bring the teachings of Lord Caitanya in the English language to the whole world.

11. The Breadth of Translation — Every Language on Earth

Śrīla Prabhupāda's Guru Mahārāja said: 'In the English language' — and within that seed, because the English language at the time was the world's most universal language, through English, all the languages of the world. And that is exactly what Śrīla Prabhupāda did. He took the Sanskrit and Bengali originals, translated them into English with the full depth of commentaries and purports drawing upon all the great ācāryas throughout history — and then had them translated into language after language.

Hundreds and hundreds of millions of books, in practically every country in the world. Just a couple of years ago, devotees were distributing books in Antarctica. And Śrīla Prabhupāda had a very special passion to spread Kṛṣṇa consciousness in India. In many ways — as we spoke here, as it appeared in his own observations — he went to America to influence the people of America, so that the people of America would influence the people of India, so that the people of India would influence the whole world. That is one way of seeing it. There are many ways of appreciating the profundity of what he did.

12. The Ācāryas of the Paramparā — A River of Living Grace

At Bhārata-bhūmi — the sacred land of India — what Śrīla Prabhupāda did in his compassion, his selfless service, was to come and beg people who had no faith, people who were addicted to so many activities far from Kṛṣṇa consciousness, to please — please — accept the happiness of loving devotional service to Kṛṣṇa. And he has asked us to assist him in this.

And Śrīla Prabhupāda was a descendent of Goloka Vṛndāvana — this is our essential faith. But he described it himself: 'Whatever qualification I have, it is only because I am simply repeating the message in the service of my spiritual master.'

When we offer obeisances to Śrīla Prabhupāda and surrender to please him, we recognise through him that glorious legacy of love, compassion, mercy, knowledge, and wisdom that he represents — flowing back through: Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura — the embodiment of fearless preaching, the force of transformation; Śrīla Gaura-kīśora dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja — the very embodiment of vipralambha (viraha), renunciation and pure love in separation; Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — who taught such a rich variety of ways a sincere soul could please and love Kṛṣṇa.

Mahāprabhu's teachings establish the principle of acintya-bhedābheda — inconceivable simultaneous difference and non-difference, unity and diversity. And the ācāryas of our tradition embody that principle in their very lives.

13. Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — The Gṛhasṭha Ācārya

Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura was a gṛhasṭha — a householder. He was a staunch practitioner, but he lived fully within the world. He took initiation from Śrīla Vipinā-vihārī Gosvāmī, and his principal śikṣā-guru was the extraordinarily austere Śrīla Jagannātha dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja — whose stories and ideal are beyond human ability to fully comprehend. And yet both great souls gave their entire lives to hearing from, receiving the blessings of, and carrying out the mission of Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura.

Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura was married to Bhagavatī-devī, a great devotee. They had ten children. He worked for the British administration at the time — as a magistrate, a judge, an administrator — and was posted to so many different places. Wherever the most difficult, most intractable problems existed, only Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura could deal with them. He was sent to Jagannātha Purī. He had houses in Calcutta, in Godrumadvīpa, in Jagannātha Purī, in rented accommodations across so many places. He was a complete gṛhasṭha — raised all his ten children to be great devotees, performed all his professional duties with complete responsibility and the highest honours, and retired with great distinction.

The greatest renunciates bow down to him and to his wife. And through all of this, Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura wrote thousands of beautiful songs and prayers, volumes upon volumes of books, established nāma-haṭṭas (marketplaces of the holy name) all over Bengal, travelled and preached tirelessly — incredible. And his inspiration? Śrīla Jagannātha dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja — who lived the simplest, most austere, most saintly life imaginable.

In this line, extraordinary scholars emerged: Kṛṣṇadāsa Bābājī — who did not even properly know how to read or write — and yet Baladeva Vidyābhūṣaṇa wrote one of the greatest commentaries on the Brahma-sūtra on the basis of Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam. Such is the mystical power of this lineage. Such are the Ṣaḍ Gosvāmīs of Vṛndāvana — great scholars, born in the highest and most prestigious families, who left everything behind and moved to Vṛndāvana to reveal — not only the physical land of Vṛndāvana but, through their example and their writings and teachings — what is the true path to Vṛndāvana? What is the true spirit of Vṛndāvana? And they wrote it for the whole world.

14. The Pañca-tattva — Plundering the Storehouse of Love

And there is the Pañca-tattva:

śrī-kṛṣṇa-caitanya prabhu-nityānanda | śrī-advaita gadādhara śrīvāsādi-gaura-bhākta-vṛnda ||
(Pañca-tattva praṇāma-mantra)

They plundered the storehouse of love of God. They tasted its contents themselves. And then they distributed it without any consideration of who was fit or unfit in this age of Kali. That is their extraordinary generosity.

And that message — Golokera prema-dhana hari-nāma-saṅkīrtana — the treasure of love from Goloka, the holy name in congregational chanting — is the very culture of the highest realm of the spiritual world, which Śrī Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa have brought into this world: through the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, through the līlā of Vṛndāvana, and manifested for the whole world in the most accessible way through Lord Caitanya and the Pañca-tattva.

15. What Is Initiation? — Honouring the Gift with Gratitude

What is initiation? To deeply honour, with gratitude, what we are receiving — and to never take it cheaply. The Bhāgavatam warns: if we do not honour with gratitude the value of the gift we are receiving, we will simply not understand the gift. To humble ourselves — to be deeply, genuinely grateful and to appreciate what we are receiving — and not just in an emotional way but alongside the emotion, to live with it. To allow our entire life to become an expression of how we want to reciprocate with the gift we are receiving. And accordingly — that is how we make spiritual progress. That is how we receive Kṛṣṇa's grace.

16. The Formal Commitment — Connection to All the Ācāryas

Today, each of you is making a formal commitment. And according to the sincerity of how we are willing to commit ourselves and live with that commitment — we are being given an inconceivably precious connection with all the ācāryas of our whole Guru-paramparā: from Śrī Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa in the spiritual world, to Brahmā and Nārada and Vyāsa and Madhvācārya, to Mādhavendra Purī, to Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu and all the great souls we have been discussing.

We are opening our hearts to take shelter of this current of grace, mercy, and love that Śrīla Prabhupāda has given to us.

Within Śrīla Prabhupāda's movement — like anything in this world — there are problems, confusions, and difficulties. It is easy to be bewildered unless we are very sincere in seeking the essence. We are not overly concerned with problems — we may have to deal with them — but we should not be bewildered or discouraged by those who do not follow. We should be seeking faith, inspiration, shelter, and spiritual strength from those who do follow. By reading Śrīla Prabhupāda's books and by sharing this message, the culture of Vaiṣṇavism is always oriented toward the higher level of consciousness — beyond all the confusions of this material world.

Śrīla Prabhupāda was taking shelter of Kṛṣṇa when people were threatening him. And he was taking shelter of Kṛṣṇa when people were offering him aṣṭopacāra worship. He was giving Kṛṣṇa whether people were blaming him or worshipping him. We should be seeking that essence.

17. The Structure of the Sampradāya — Serving Together

Within this society there are dīkṣā-gurus, there are śikṣā-gurus, there are senior devotees, inspirational devotees — and we are all working together, all serving together, to help uplift each other in Kṛṣṇa consciousness. The flow of Prabhupāda's grace and Kṛṣṇa's mercy is very much present in your śrī-gurus — and in how you share Kṛṣṇa consciousness with each other.

I am a fairly small person — but somehow or other, this is how the Lord wants me to serve. And I am honoured to serve you. I am very, very sincerely grateful to each and every one of you for giving your hearts, your souls, your lives to sincerely strive to be Kṛṣṇa conscious — and to share that gift with each other and with the world.

18. Closing Prayer

I pray that Śrīla Prabhupāda and all of our ācāryas may shower their mercy, their grace, their love upon you — and upon all of your loved ones. And I pray that by that mercy — by Śrī Rādhā-Govinda's mukharī (blessings) — you may find great happiness in a life of Kṛṣṇa consciousness, even having passed through all situations. And I pray that you can truly be empowered to offer wonderful, sincere, whole-hearted devotional service.

Thank you very much.

Appendix — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (10 March)

1. Bhagavad-gītā 18.66 — The Final Instruction: Surrender

sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇaṁ vraja | ahaṁ tvāṁ sarva-pāpebhyo mokṣayiṣyāmi mā śucaḥ ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 18.66.

2. Bhagavad-gītā 18.65 — The Formula of Surrender

man-manā bhava mad-bhakto mad-yājī māṁ namaskuru | mām evaiṣyasi yuktvaivam ātmānaṁ mat-parāyaṇaḥ ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 18.65.

3. The Nine Processes of Devotional Service

śravaṇaṁ kīrtanaṁ viṣṇoḥ smaraṇaṁ pāda-sevanam | arcanāṁ vandanāṁ dāsyāṁ sakhyam ātma-nivedanam ||

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 7.5.23.

4. Bhagavad-gītā 7.14 — Māyā and the Grace of Surrender

daivi hy eṣā guṇamayī mama māyā duratyayā | mām eva ye prapadyante māyām etaṁ taranti te ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 7.14.

5. The Ocean Becomes a Hoofprint

*samāsritā ye pada-pallava-plavaṇaṁ mahat-padaṁ puṇya-yaśo murāreḥ | bhavāmbudhir vatsa-padaṁ paraṁ padaṁ
padaṁ padaṁ yad vipadaṁ na teṣāṁ ||*

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.14.58.

6. Purification Verse

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvāvasthām gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bāhyābhyantaraḥ śuciḥ ||

Source: Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra incorporated into ISKCON ceremonial liturgy.

7. The Śikṣāṣṭaka — Verse 1 (Paraṁ Vijayate)

*ceto-darpaṇa-mārjanam bhava-mahā-dāvāgni-nirvāpaṇam śreyah-kairava-candrikā-vitarāṇam vidyā-vadhu-jīvanam |
ānandāmbudhi-vardhanam prati-padam pūṇāmṛtāsvādanam sarvātma-snāpanam paraṁ vijayate śrī-kṛṣṇa-
saṅkīrtanam ||*

Source: Śikṣāṣṭaka 1, by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Antya-līlā 20.12.

8. Pañca-tattva Praṇāma

śrī-kṛṣṇa-caitanya prabhu-nityānanda | śrī-advaita gadādhara śrīvāsādi-gaura-bhakta-vṛnda ||

Source: Standard ISKCON Pañca-tattva praṇāma-mantra.

9. Mahājano Yena Gataḥ — Following the Great Souls

dharmasya glāniḥ... mahājano yena gataḥ sa panthāḥ

Source: Mahābhārata, Vana-parva 313.117; often cited in Gauḍīya literature.

Key People, Concepts, and Terms — 10 March

Śaraṇāgati	Complete surrender to the Supreme Lord; the foundation of the entire path of bhakti
Śikṣāṣṭaka	Eight instructional verses composed personally by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu — the only writings He left
Nārada Muni	The celestial sage who instructed Vyāsadeva to compile the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam as the essence of all Vedic knowledge
Vyāsadeva	Compiler of the four Vedas, Upaniṣads, Purāṇas, Mahābhārata, and Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam
Acintya-bhedābheda	The philosophical principle of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu: inconceivable simultaneous difference and non-difference
Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura	The ācārya who revived Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇavism in the 19th century; gṛhastha, judge, prolific writer
Bhagavatī-devī	Wife of Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura; a great devotee; they had ten children together
Jagannātha dāsa Bābājī Mahārāja	Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura's śikṣā-guru; the greatest renunciate of the age; lived at Navadvīpa
Baladeva Vidyābhūṣaṇa	Great Gauḍīya ācārya and scholar; wrote the Govinda-bhāṣya commentary on the Brahma-sūtra
Nāma-haṭṭa	The 'marketplace of the holy name'; congregational preaching program established by Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura
Golokera prema-dhana hari-nāma-saṅkīrtana	'The treasure of love from Goloka — hari-nāma-saṅkīrtana'; a celebrated teaching of the tradition

Pañca-tattva	The five-fold form of the Absolute: Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, Prabhu Nityānanda, Śrī Advaita, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura
Dīkṣā-guru	The initiating spiritual master who gives the first and second initiations
Śikṣā-guru	The instructing spiritual master from whom one receives guidance and teachings
Bhārata-bhūmi	The sacred land of India; in the Gauḍīya tradition, it carries a special responsibility to spread Kṛṣṇa consciousness
Vatsa-padam	Hoofprint of a calf — used metaphorically for how Kṛṣṇa's grace reduces the vast ocean of māyā
Hlādinī-śakti	Śrī Rādhā as the pleasure potency of Kṛṣṇa; the supreme reservoir of all love
GEV	Govardhan Eco Village, Wada, Palghar district, ~80 km north of Mumbai

11 March 2026

Initiation Lecture — 11 March 2026

Harinām-dīkṣā Ceremony — The Appearance Day of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura

1. The Opening Verse — Pure or Impure, in All Situations

apavitraḥ pavitro vā sarvavasthaṁ gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣaṁ sa bahyabhyantaraḥ śuciḥ ||
(Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra)

Whether we are purified or not pure — or even having passed through all situations of life — one who remembers the beautiful lotus-eyed Supreme Personality of Godhead is purified both internally and externally.

On behalf of His Divine Grace, Śrīla A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda — and in honour of our most beloved and worshipped ācāryas of the Brahma-Mādhva-Gauḍīya Sampradāya — we now begin this ceremony for harinām-dīkṣā initiation.

Śrīla Prabhupāda had us recite this particular verse on whatever occasions we make lifelong commitments: whether we are pure or impure, when we remember the Supreme Lord — even while having passed through all the various situations of life — we become purified. Kṛṣṇa is pāvitra — He is supremely pure. And coming into contact with His supreme purity is how the impurity of our conditioned existence is dissolved.

2. Kṛṣṇa as the Source of All — The Ontological Foundation

ahaṁ sarvasya prabhavo mattaḥ sarvaṁ pravartate | iti matvā bhajante mām budhā bhāva-samanvitāḥ ||
Translation: I am the source of all spiritual and material worlds. Everything emanates from Me. The wise who know this perfectly engage in My devotional service and worship Me with all their hearts.

(Bhagavad-gītā 10.8)

Kṛṣṇa is the source of all spiritual and all material worlds. Everything and everyone emanates from that Supreme Truth — the Personality of Godhead. And the material energy of Māyā — māyādhyaḥkṣeṇa prakṛtiḥ — which is Kṛṣṇa's own energy, is always under Kṛṣṇa's complete control.

All the great Vaiṣṇava ācāryas — Śrī Rāmānujācārya, Śrī Madhvācārya, Śrī Nimbārkaācārya, Śrī Vallabhācārya — have cited from Vedic evidence, and with philosophy, logic, and most of all pure realisation and ecstatic love, established the truth that differentiates the Supreme Lord from the individual spirit soul. The Paramātmā — the Supersoul — is the master of all energies, the source of all beings.

3. The Soul and the Supersoul — Sun and Sunray

mamāivāṁśo jīva-loke jīva-bhūtaḥ sanātanaḥ |

Translation: The living entities in this conditioned world are My eternal fragmental parts.

(Bhagavad-gītā 15.7)

Every spirit soul is eternally a part and parcel of the Supreme. Jīva Gosvāmī offers the most beautiful analogy to illuminate this truth: compare the sun planet and the sun ray.

Qualitatively, a sun ray possesses the same qualities as the sun itself — heat and light — coming from the same source and of the same substance. But quantitatively, the sun ray is always an insignificant speck compared to the sun. And the sun is always the origin of the sun ray — never the other way around.

Can you imagine the sun planet feeling itself subordinate to a single sunray? That is inconceivable. And yet — that is the nature of Kṛṣṇa's love. Kṛṣṇa loves to be conquered by His devotees. This is one of the most extraordinary, most inconceivable truths of the entire Vedic tradition. Some engineers from IIT, astronomers, astrologers, biologists, mathematicians — with all their formulas and intelligence — this simple principle is something that confounds all of it. How inconceivable it is, this simple statement: Kṛṣṇa finds the greatest pleasure in being overwhelmed by the love of His devotees.

4. Mahāprabhu's Teaching at Vārāṇasī — The Two-Month Discourse to Sanātana Gosvāmī

Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu put extraordinary emphasis on this philosophical foundation when He was in Vārāṇasī. He gave instructions to Śrīla Sanātana Gosvāmī for two full months, throughout the course of each day. And in those teachings He established everything: the nature of the soul (jīva-tattva); the nature of God (kṛṣṇa-tattva); the nature of material existence (māyā-tattva); the various forms of the Lord and the various Vaikuṇṭha planets; the all-pervading Brahman and the distinctions of nirviśeṣa and saviśeṣa understanding; the various incarnations that come to this earth planet; the essence of karma, jñāna, and yoga — and how all of these ultimately are fulfilled in bhakti; the nature of pure bhakti — and then going deeper, into the internal emotional ecstasies of love (bhāva and mahā-bhāva); the nature of the loving relationships of the residents of Vṛndāvana in the spiritual world.

And He began His teachings on this simple foundation — to give us the ādi-tattva, the first and most essential truth:

jīvera svarūpa haya kṛṣṇera nitya-dāsa

Translation: The constitutional nature of every living being is that we are eternally servants of Kṛṣṇa.

(Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 20.108)

This is not a philosophical position among many. This is the svarūpa — the actual constitutional identity — of every living entity without exception.

5. 'Bhakti Means to Serve' — A Memory from Vṛndāvana, August 1971

I remember when I first came to Vṛndāvana. This was in August of 1971. I was brought there — I had no intention to go there. I did not even know what it was. But by Kṛṣṇa's arrangement, I found myself there.

I was reading extensively at the time — Bhagavad-gītā, Rāmāyaṇa, the Upaniṣads, teachings of so many ācāryas of the Advaita school. I was learning a great deal and meeting so many people. And one day I was in the company of a very, very dear sādhu — an extraordinarily pure soul. I was simply trying to understand: What is this Vṛndāvana?

And this person spoke one sentence. Something very simple. And I realised in that moment that if I dedicated my whole life to this one sentence, maybe — maybe — I would begin to understand it. May I share that sentence with you?

'Bhakti means to serve.'

Simple. Three words. But that one sentence is a seed that contains within it the entire ascent — all the way up to what Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu is truly giving us: Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī is serving Kṛṣṇa as the supreme reservoir of all love. Kṛṣṇa finds the greatest pleasure in serving the devotees. The devotee always feels subordinate to Kṛṣṇa's love. And Kṛṣṇa, by His own sweet will, wants to feel subordinate to the love of His devotee.

That is a cintya — that is truly, genuinely inconceivable. Sometimes the simplest things are the most inconceivable of all. 'Bhakti means to serve.' A whole life — many lifetimes — could be devoted to entering that depth.

6. Kṛṣṇa's Pastimes — The Butter Thief and the Lord of All

Without first understanding the greatness and the glory of God as presented in Bhagavad-gītā and in the first nine chapters of the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, it is very difficult to honestly appreciate who Kṛṣṇa truly is. He is so playful. He steals butter. And when caught, He will say: 'I didn't steal it.' And when His mother holds Him and says, 'I saw you steal it' — He will cry, and His lips will quiver, and He will say: 'Please, please don't hurt me.'

Who is He? His expansion's expansion — that same Kṛṣṇa — is Lord Narasiṃha, who terrified Hiraṇyakaśipu — the most powerful demon who had conquered all the demigods, far more powerful than Rāvaṇa and all the others. And that same God is crying in front of mother Yaśodā saying: 'Please, Mother, put down your stick.'

This is the extraordinary acintya — the inconceivable. By remembering Kṛṣṇa, we are in the presence of Kṛṣṇa. And that is Kṛṣṇa's inconceivable mercy. Kṛṣṇa is enjoying the highest rāsa of love with His eternal associates in the spiritual world. And we are here in this material world — so many of us afflicted by envy, lust, anger, greed, arrogance, illusion.

7. Kṛṣṇa as the Supreme Proprietor — Everything Is His

iśāvāsyam idaṁ sarvaṁ yat kiñca jagatyāṁ jagat

Translation: Everything that exists in this universe is the property of the Lord.

(Śrī Īśopaniṣad 1)

And yet we say: 'This is mine.' God gives us intelligence — and we say, 'This is my intelligence; I am better than you.' Kṛṣṇa gives us abilities — and we say, 'I can do this better than you.' We want to be glorified. We want to take credit. We want to feel that we possess what we have.

But ultimately — in the form of death — Kṛṣṇa will take everything away from everyone, without exception. But if in this lifetime we recognise that Kṛṣṇa is the supreme enjoyer and we are meant to be enjoyed by Kṛṣṇa — that Kṛṣṇa is the supreme proprietor — then our real happiness, our true nature, is to utilise whatever we have — whatever influence, intelligence, abilities, possessions — in Kṛṣṇa's service. That is the only happiness on the spiritual platform.

Everything else may give the illusory conception of happiness. But even that happiness creates only further entanglement in a cycle that will inevitably cause suffering and death.

This is not pessimistic. It is actually the most optimistic view of all. If someone tells you: 'Don't go down this street — it's a dead end' — and you reply, 'You are a pessimist' — you will waste your time on that dead-end street. If that same person says: 'Go down this road — it will take you where you want to go' — that is optimism. The problem is that if we don't know this is a dead-end street, we won't know the difference. And initiation is the formal moment of beginning to know the difference.

8. Initiation — Connecting to the Paramparā

This initiation ceremony is to connect ourselves — through a formal commitment — to being servants of the servant of the Supreme Personality of Godhead. We have recited prayers to many of our great ācāryas at the commencement of today's ceremony, meditating upon how, through paramparā, at the very origin of this universe, Kṛṣṇa instructs transcendental knowledge and the way to practise it to Brahmā.

Brahmā shared this with the great Nārada Muni. Nārada instructed Asita and the sages. And the great Madhvācārya — he walked by foot all the way from Udupi to Badrī Nārāyaṇa in the Himalayas. Many of you are from North India — so you understand how far and how high that is. And then he went from Badrī Nārāyaṇa to Ādi Badrī — even higher, a transcendental realm inaccessible to ordinary human beings — to the āśrama of Vyāsadeva: the author of the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, the compiler of the Purāṇas, the Vedānta-sūtra, the Mahābhārata, the Bhagavad-gītā, the Upaniṣads, the four Vedas. The essence of everything that Vyāsadeva knew — learned from Nārada, from Brahmā, from Kṛṣṇa directly — is pure devotional service.

9. Mādhavendra Purī — The Root of the Tree

And so many great saints were in the disciplic line of Madhvācārya — and eventually, the extraordinary Mādhavendra Purī. He was an eternal loving associate of Śrī Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa in Goloka Vṛndāvana. He was personally sent by Rādhārāṇī and Kṛṣṇa to be like the root of the tree of Their incarnation as Lord Caitanya. Mādhavendra Purī had so many great disciples: Nityānanda Prabhu; Paramānanda Purī; Brahmānanda Purī; Advaita Ācārya; Puṇḍarīka Vidyānidhi; and one particular disciple: Śrī Īśvarapurī.

Īśvarapurī was very learned and very pure in every way. But of all these great, great ācāryas — all of whom were avatāras of the Supreme Truth — why did Lord Caitanya decide to take initiation from Īśvarapurī specifically? All the disciples of Mādhavendra Purī were absolutely qualified. The answer reveals the heart of the entire philosophy of dikṣā.

10. Lord Caitanya Takes Initiation — Teaching the Principle of Servitude

Lord Caitanya — rādhā-bhāva-dyuti-suvalitaṁ naumi kṛṣṇa-svarūpam — is Kṛṣṇa, who has come to taste the sweetness of Śrī Rādhā's love, and to share that love with the people of this world. And He came in the role of a devotee to teach us how to be devotees.

Śrīla Prabhupāda explains it with a sweet illustration: when a teacher in elementary school teaches a child how to write the alphabet, the teacher says — "This is how you draw an A. This is a slanted line this way, and a slanted line this way, and then a straight line in the middle." The teacher does not need to go through these lessons. But the teacher goes through the lessons to teach us how to do the lessons. So to teach us how to be devotees, the Lord Himself comes in the role of a devotee.

Kṛṣṇa appeared 4,500 years before Lord Caitanya. He spoke the Bhagavad-gītā. The knowledge is there — what is the body, what is the mind, what is the eternal soul, how material nature works, who is the Supreme Lord, how to achieve perfection:

man-manā bhava mad-bhaktō mad-yājī mām namaskuru | mām evaiṣyasi yuktvaivam ātmānaṁ mat-parīyaṇaḥ ||

Translation: Always think of Me! Become My devotee. Worship Me. Offer Your homage to Me. In this way, You will come to Me without fail.

(Bhagavad-gītā 18.65)

And then Kṛṣṇa says: 'I promise you this — because you are My dear friend.' This was Kṛṣṇa's promise.

And in one sense, initiation is simply reciprocating with that promise. Kṛṣṇa promised: 'If you just remember Me, you will come to Me without fail.' So what are we doing today? We are promising Kṛṣṇa: 'I will remember You. I will be Your devotee. I will worship You. I will offer my homage to You.' We are the fulfilling side of a divine promise — the promise Kṛṣṇa has already made. We are saying: 'Yes.'

11. The Essence of Being a Devotee

ataḥ pumbhir dvija-śreṣṭhā varṇāśrama-vibhāgaśaḥ | svanuṣṭhitasya dharmaśya saṁsiddhir hari-toṣaṇam ||

Translation: The highest perfection one can achieve by discharging the duties prescribed for one's own occupation according to caste divisions and orders of life is to please the Personality of Godhead.

(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.13)

The goal of every role we may have in this world — the essence of all dharma — is to give pleasure to Kṛṣṇa. That is what it means to be a devotee. It does not just mean wearing a kanthi-mālā and tilaka and having a Sanskrit name. Being a devotee means our actions, our words, our thoughts, our entire life — moment after moment after moment — striving to please Kṛṣṇa. How do we please Kṛṣṇa? No one knows better than Kṛṣṇa Himself. Therefore Kṛṣṇa performed His Vṛndāvana-līlā — and revealed it through Vyāsadeva in the pages of Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam.

But to actually learn how to live in this world — not merely imitating gopas and gopīs — Lord Caitanya came to teach us the actual path to that destination. And taking initiation is the formal beginning of that journey.

12. Lord Caitanya Did Not Preach Until He Accepted Initiation

Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu did not begin to preach or establish the saṅkīrtana movement until He accepted initiation from Śrī Īśvarapurī — precisely to show the importance of being the servant of a servant. He was digvijayī-panḍita — having defeated in debate even the famous scholar Keśava Kāśmīrī, the most celebrated panḍita of his time. He was the most famous scholar in all of Navadvīpa. Even great devotees like Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura — whose appearance day we are celebrating this very day — were deeply aware of Him.

Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura had been chanting and praying for years to bring Lord Caitanya down to this world, along with Advaita Ācārya and Haridāsa Ṭhākura. He was holding kīrtanas in his home. And when Lord Caitanya — still acting as a teacher and professor — would argue with everybody and defeat everyone in scholarly debate, whenever He would meet Śrīvāsa, He would very respectfully offer His praṇāms. And Śrīvāsa would say: 'Nimāi — why are you wasting your life with all these mundane pursuits? You should worship Kṛṣṇa. You should chant the holy names of Kṛṣṇa.'

He spoke with such genuine, deep compassion. And Nimāi did not argue with Śrīvāsa. Rather, He would bow respectfully and say: 'Because I have received this blessing from such a great devotee as you — someday I will be a devotee of Kṛṣṇa.' He is teaching us: without the blessings of great souls, Kṛṣṇa will not truly be pleased with us.

13. Īśvarapurī and Mādhavendra Purī — The Supreme Example of Service to the Guru

When Īśvarapurī came to Navadvīpa, Lord Caitanya would go and hear from him. There is a beautiful story in which Īśvarapurī asked Nimāi to edit his book — 'Kṛṣṇa-līlāmṛta.' Nimāi read it and came back and showed how it could be improved in a particular place. And Īśvarapurī said:

'No — actually that is correct as I wrote it.' And Nīmāi accepted defeat. That was impossible for Nīmāi — the greatest scholar in Navadvīpa, who defeated everyone — to accept defeat before any ordinary scholar. But he wanted to show Īśvarapurī how deeply Īśvarapurī's own guru, Mādhavendra Purī, had served him.

If you meditate on this story, it is extraordinary. Mādhavendra Purī was travelling, preaching, bringing so many people to Kṛṣṇa consciousness — developing, embodying, radiating pure love. But in his last stages, he could no longer sit up. He could not stand. And Īśvarapurī was there — not to take anything from his guru, but to give everything: cleaning the excrement of his guru with his own hands; washing his guru's body; chanting the names of Kṛṣṇa and the pastimes of Kṛṣṇa for his guru's pleasure — continuously.

He was not there saying: 'Guru Mahārāja, give me instruction.' He was giving to his guru, for his guru's pleasure. Because he was performing such menial service — as the servant of the servant — Mādhavendra Purī was so pleased with him. And he said: 'My child — may you have devotion to Kṛṣṇa.'

That blessing — from the root of the tree of Lord Caitanya's incarnation — descended into Īśvarapurī. And Lord Caitanya Himself went to Gayā especially to take initiation from Īśvarapurī. There, Lord Caitanya humbly served him — massaging his feet and legs, cooking for him, cleaning the vessels — all menial service, exactly as his guru had done for his guru. And Īśvarapurī gave the instruction: 'You should always chant the holy names of Kṛṣṇa and spread the saṅkīrtana movement all over.'

Lord Caitanya began chanting. He was feeling great ecstasy. He went back to Īśvarapurī and said: 'What is happening to me?' And Īśvarapurī said: 'My child — I am very happy. You have attained perfection. Now spread this saṅkīrtana everywhere.'

Later, in Vārāṇasī, Lord Caitanya told Prakāśānanda Sarasvatī Mahārāja: 'My guru gave me this instruction: 'You will never understand all Vedic knowledge merely by studying books. You chant the names of Kṛṣṇa.'"

14. The Six Gosvāmīs — Establishing Vṛndāvana for the World

Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu among all His great followers sent the Ṣaḍ Gosvāmīs to Vṛndāvana — especially to establish the glories of Vṛndāvana for the whole world: Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī; Śrīla Sanātana Gosvāmī; Śrīla Raghunātha Bhaṭṭa Gosvāmī; Śrīla Gopāla Bhaṭṭa Gosvāmī; Śrīla Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī; Śrīla Jīva Gosvāmī.

Each one — every aspect of their lives — teaches us the essence of all perfection. They established the glories of pure devotional service in Vṛndāvana through their character, their culture, and how they lived. They established temples at holy places. They wrote books. The life of each Gosvāmī — every detail — is a teaching on what the essence of devotional perfection truly is.

15. The Generation After — From Gosvāmīs to Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura

The generation after the Six Gosvāmīs produced such great ācāryas as: Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura — nāma-ācārya, composer of incomparable devotional songs; Śrīnivāsa Ācārya — who carried the Gosvāmī books from Vṛndāvana to Bengal; Śyāmānanda Gosvāmī — who established Kṛṣṇa consciousness in Orissa.

And then in the disciplic line of Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura: Viśvanātha Cakravartī Ṭhākura — such a scholar, who revealed the highest essence of the rāsa-śāstra, and whose character was the embodiment of that essence. In his line: Baladeva Vidyābhūṣaṇa — and through him, the line flows to Bhagavat-dāsa Bābājī — and to Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura.

16. Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — The Bhajana at Home in the Forest

His wife — Bhagavatī-devī — and he had ten children. And next month we are going to have a beautiful ceremony in Calcutta, where we are opening the very house that Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura personally had built — I believe it was in 1882. It is a large house. And as they were digging the foundation, they discovered a Kūrma-śilā — a sacred stone in the form of Lord Kūrma (the tortoise incarnation). When Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura's son — his most beloved child, later to become Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura — was only about seven years old, Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura gave him that śilā to establish his worship of Lord Kṛṣṇa. And he raised his children mainly in that house. He established a printing press there, published his books there, distributed them from there.

He wrote books, poems, songs, prayers, and commentaries on scriptures — volumes and volumes — all from that house and from other residences. Such an ācārya. Such an example.

And he gave us this beautiful teaching — a teaching that Lord Caitanya Himself sang:

gṛhe thāko, vane thāko, sadā hari bolo re | śukte-pake bhāgavat-cintā, koriho re ||

Translation: Whether you live at home or in the forest, always chant Hari's names!
Whether you are eating simply or richly, always think of the Bhāgavatam!

(Bhajana attributed to Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura, reflecting the spirit of Śikṣaṣṭaka)

Here you are — gṛhastha with husbands or wives, children, and jobs. Or perhaps a sannyāsī in a monastery, a brahmacārī, or living alone. These are details. Just by taking shelter of the holy names of Kṛṣṇa, you can rise above all the happiness and distress of material existence.

17. The Higher Taste — Param Dṛṣṭvā Nivartate

viṣayā vinivartante nirāhāsyā dehinaḥ | rasa-varjam raso 'py asya param dṛṣṭvā nivartate ||

Translation: The embodied soul may be restricted from sense enjoyment, though the taste for sense objects remains. But ceasing such engagements by experiencing a higher taste, one is fixed in consciousness.

(Bhagavad-gītā 2.59)

When we develop the higher taste of pleasing Kṛṣṇa — satisfying Kṛṣṇa, loving Kṛṣṇa — all the so-called goals that promise happiness in this world are revealed for what they truly are: insignificant. Without that loving service to Kṛṣṇa, those illusory forms of happiness seemed so important — only because we had not yet experienced something higher. They seemed worth dedicating our lives to achieve — only because we had not yet tasted the infinite.

And that is what Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura came to give us — and through him, his son and spiritual successor, Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura Prabhupāda.

18. Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta and the 1922 Meeting — 1 Billion Names of Kṛṣṇa

Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura lived in Māyāpura and chanted one billion names of Kṛṣṇa over approximately ten years. Then he came to Calcutta to start preaching. I believe he first went to Bhakti-bhavana — his mother's house — and after some time they found a rented place at Ultadanga Junction Road. That was in 1918. In 1922, he gave that historic instruction.

He told a young man: 'You are educated. You should take the message of Lord Caitanya in the English language all over the world.'

Śrīla Prabhupāda took that instruction as his life and soul. He took the message to the very feet of the guru. But also — because he valued his Guru's instruction — he valued the love, the compassion, and the grace flowing through his guru through the whole paramparā of great ācāryas. He had such faith. He left everything. He left everything to go to Vṛndāvana to prepare. Then he left Vṛndāvana. He left everything — and then he even left that. That was the ocean of compassion in Śrīla Prabhupāda's heart for all of us.

And when he got on that ship — the SS Jaladūta — he said: 'I had nothing and no one. But I had the instruction of my Guru Mahārāja. I had the Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam. And I had faith in the holy name of Kṛṣṇa.'

19. Kṛṣṇa Has Incarnated in His Name — The Supreme Gift for Kali-yuga

In this age of quarrel and hypocrisy — Kali-yuga — Kṛṣṇa has incarnated in His name:

nāmnām akāri bahudhā nija-sarva-śaktis tatbrāpitā niyamitaḥ smaraṇe na kālāḥ | etādṛśī tava kṛpā bhagavan mamāpi durdaivam idṛśam ibājani nānurāgaḥ ||

Translation: O my Lord, Your holy name alone can render all benediction to living beings, and thus You have hundreds and millions of names, like Kṛṣṇa and Govinda. In these transcendental names You have invested all Your transcendental energies. There are not even hard and fast rules for chanting these names. O my Lord, out of kindness You enable us to easily approach You by Your holy names, but I am so unfortunate that I have no attraction for them.

(Śikṣaṣṭaka 2, by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu)

Kṛṣṇa has infused within His name — Himself. Śrī Rādhā is personally present within the sound of the holy names. All Their power, Their mercy, Their love, Their beauty, Their supreme abode, the association of Their loving devotees, Their qualities — they are coming in the holy names to

reveal all these supreme treasures of the spiritual world to us: simple, confused, fallen people of Kali-yuga. That is what Śrīla Prabhupāda brought with him on the Jaladūta.

And the verse that Lord Caitanya's Guru gave — which through the entire paramparā we have been chanting:

hare nāma hare nāma hare nāmaiva kevalam | kalan nāsty eva nāsty eva nāsty eva gatir anyathā ||
(Bṛhan-nāradya Purāṇa 38.126)

And the Bhāgavatam confirms:

kaler doṣa-nidhe rājann asti hy eko mahān guṇaḥ | kīrtanād eva kṛṣṇasya mukta-saṅgaḥ paraṁ vrajet ||
(Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 12.3.51)

20. The Commitment We Are Making Today

This beautiful ceremony of initiation is committing ourselves. And in that commitment, we are accepting the current of grace that is flowing through the whole paramparā — through Śrīla Prabhupāda's heart — into our own lives.

It is not just a commitment to chant a minimum of sixteen rounds daily — though that is the foundational principle. It is not just a commitment to follow the moral, cultural, and ethical values — no intoxication, no gambling, no meat-eating, no illicit sex. It is also a commitment to live with the culture and character of a Vaiṣṇava.

Śrīla Prabhupāda extracted so much of the essence of the great ācāryas into his books — and worked so hard to give them to us — and asked us to deeply study them according to our capacity. Not only to chant Kṛṣṇa's names, but to learn, to witness the great souls, and to hear the philosophy behind how to chant Kṛṣṇa's names.

Śrīla Prabhupāda would sometimes say: 'A Vaiṣṇava means to have no envy.' He would sometimes say: 'A Vaiṣṇava means to sincerely feel the suffering of others.' He would say: 'A Vaiṣṇava means to always remember Kṛṣṇa.' We have our shortcomings and our conditionings — and we should not get depressed because we are not yet on that level. But we understand what we are striving for. What is really valuable. And we sincerely try our best.

Just a few days ago, somebody was sharing some difficulties they were having and asked for an instruction. I said: 'Try your best.' And the person said: 'How can I honestly say I am really trying my best?' And when I thought about that, I said: 'Sincerely try.' That is something we can all actually do — something we can definitely commit to. That means we are really, genuinely striving.

21. Rūpa Gosvāmī's Instruction — No Taste for Gossip

Śrīla Rūpa Gosvāmī describes: a Vaiṣṇava should have no taste for gossip or mundane criticism. We should be seeking the taste of talking about Kṛṣṇa and hearing about Kṛṣṇa. Talking and hearing about pure devotional service. Trying to inspire Vaiṣṇavas. Trying to encourage Vaiṣṇavas.

And trying to create communities that will actually attract the world away from all the quarrel and hypocrisy of the environment of Kali-yuga.

My sincere request and expectation of you: do not get caught up in all the political situations happening all over the world. For those of you who follow world news — Kali-yuga is a place of quarrel and hypocrisy. We have been reading about it in the scriptures and we are seeing the evidence all around us today. There is so much danger at every step for everyone. At any moment, people could die, could suffer, could lose their loved ones. What do we fight about?

If we do not have a really pure serving spirit — if we are not genuinely striving for the essence — somehow or other we will always find some rationale to fight about things that are not worthy of fighting about. We want to prove ourselves. We want to control things. And therefore we find so many reasons to argue, to separate, to fight. Śrīla Prabhupāda instructed us: 'You can show your love for me by how you cooperate for the higher purpose of serving this mission.'

And saṅkīrtana means: together we are rising above the tendencies of Kali-yuga by sincerely helping one another take shelter of the holy names.

22. The Auspicious Day — The Appearance of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura

This ceremony is being held on the most auspicious appearance day of Śrī Śrīvāsa Paṇḍita — Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura. He was chanting and praying for years, calling Lord Caitanya to descend to this world. He was having kīrtanas in his home. His courtyard — the Śrīvāsa-āṅgana — was the birthplace of the congregational saṅkīrtana movement. Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura gave everything — his home, his energy, his family's support — to nurture the earliest and most intimate expressions of Mahāprabhu's movement.

To take initiation on his appearance day is an extraordinary blessing. We are receiving the mercy of one who was most intimate with Lord Caitanya — one of the Pañca-tattva's closest associates. May his mercy descend upon all of us.

23. The Structure of the Community — Serving Together

We have dīkṣā-gurus, śikṣā-gurus, temple presidents, saṅkīrtana leaders, pujārīs, book distributors, mothers, fathers — so many devotees with so many different roles within our movement. And essentially, we are all trying to serve together to fulfil the mission of our founder-ācārya, A.C. Bhaktivedānta Svāmī Prabhupāda.

Please be faithful. Be loyal. Be devoted.

Thank you very much.

Appendix A — Sanskrit Verses Referenced (11 March)

1. Purification Mantra (Śuddhi-mantra)

āpavitrah pavitro vā sarvāvasthām gato 'pi vā | yaḥ smaret puṇḍarikākṣam sa bāhyābhyantarah śuciḥ ||

Source: Traditional Vaiṣṇava śuddhi-mantra.

2. Kṛṣṇa as the Source of All

ahaṁ sarvasya prabhavo mattaḥ sarvaṁ pravartate | iti matvā bhajante mām budhā bhāva-samanvitāḥ ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 10.8.

3. The Soul as Eternal Part of the Supreme

mamāivāṁśo jīva-loke jīva-bhūtaḥ sanātanaḥ |

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 15.7.

4. The Constitutional Position of the Soul

jīvera svarūpa haya kṛṣṇera nitya-dāsa

Source: Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 20.108.

5. Kṛṣṇa as Supreme Proprietor

īśāvāsyam idaṁ sarvaṁ yat kiñca jagatyām jagat

Source: Śrī Īśopaniṣad 1.

6. The Perfection of Dharma — Pleasing Kṛṣṇa

ataḥ pumbhir dvija-śreṣṭhā varṇāśrama-vibhāgaśaḥ | svanuṣṭhitasya dharmasya saṁsiddhir hari-toṣaṇam ||

Source: Śrīmad-Bhagavatam 1.2.13.

7. Bhagavad-gītā 18.65 — Always Think of Kṛṣṇa

man-manā bhava mad-bhaktō mad-yājī mām namaskuru | mām evaiṣyasi yuktvaivam ātmānam mat-parīyaṇaḥ ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 18.65.

8. The Rādhā-bhāva Verse — Lord Caitanya's Identity

rādhā-bhāva-dyuti-sūvalitaṁ naumi kṛṣṇa-svarūpam

Source: Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Ādi-līlā 1.5 (partial citation).

9. Bhajana of Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura — At Home or in the Forest

gr̥he thāko, vane thāko, sadā hari bolo re | śukte-pāke bhāgavat-cintā, koribo re ||

Source: Bhajana in the spirit of the Śikṣāṣṭaka, by Śrīla Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura.

10. Bhagavad-gītā 2.59 — The Higher Taste

viṣayaḥ vinivartante nirāharasya debinaḥ | rasa-varjaṁ raso 'py asya paraṁ dṛṣṭvā nivartate ||

Source: Bhagavad-gītā 2.59.

11. Śikṣāṣṭaka 2 — The Name Contains All Potency

nāmnām akāri babudhā nija-sarva-śaktis tatbrāpitā niyamitaḥ smaraṇe na kālāḥ | etādṛśī tava kṛpā bhagavan mamāpi durdaivam idṛśam ibhājani nānuraḡaḥ ||

Source: Śikṣāṣṭaka 2, by Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu; cited in Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Āntya-līlā 20.16.

12. The Yuga-dharma Verse

hare nāma hare nāma hare nāmaiva kevalam | kalan nāsty eva nāsty eva nāsty eva gatir anyathā | |

Source: Br̥han-nāradya Purāṇa 38.126.

13. The Treasure of Kali-yuga

kealer doṣa-nidhe rājann asti hy eko mahān guṇaḥ | kīrtanād eva kṛṣṇasya mukta-saṅgaḥ paraṁ vrajet | |

Source: Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 12.3.51.

Appendix B — Historical and Devotional Notes (11 March)

Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura	Eternal associate of Lord Caitanya; his appearance day is being celebrated (11 March 2026); his courtyard (Śrīvāsa-āṅgana) was the birthplace of the saṅkīrtana movement
Mādhavendra Purī	Root of the Gauḍīya tree; eternal associate of Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa sent to earth to be the source of Lord Caitanya's lineage
Īśvarapurī	Disciple of Mādhavendra Purī who served his guru in his last days; became the dīkṣā-guru of Lord Caitanya
Keśava Kāśmīrī	The famous digvijayī scholar whom Lord Caitanya debated in Navadvīpa — also known as Prakāśānanda Sarasvatī in some accounts
Ṣaḍ Gosvāmīs	The Six Gosvāmīs of Vṛndāvana: Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha Bhaṭṭa, Gopāla Bhaṭṭa, Raghunātha dāsa, Jīva Gosvāmīs
Narottama dāsa Ṭhākura	Ācārya of the generation after the Gosvāmīs; composer of extraordinary devotional songs
Viśvanātha Cakravartī Ṭhākura	Great scholar-ācārya in the line of Narottama dāsa; revealed the highest rāsa-śāstra
Baladeva Vidyābhūṣaṇa	Wrote the Govinda-bhāṣya commentary on the Brahma-sūtra; in the line of Viśvanātha Cakravartī
Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura's Calcutta house	Built by Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura in 1882; a Kūrma-śilā was discovered during foundation digging; RNS mentions an upcoming ceremony to open this house
Kūrma-śilā	A sacred stone in the form of Lord Kūrma (the tortoise incarnation); discovered during the digging of Bhaktivinoda Ṭhākura's house foundation
Ultadanga Junction Road	The first rented preaching centre of Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura in Calcutta, established 1918
One billion names	Śrīla Bhaktisiddhānta Sarasvatī Ṭhākura chanted one billion (koṭi) holy names of Kṛṣṇa at Māyāpura over ~10 years before beginning public preaching
SS Jaladūta	The cargo ship on which Śrīla Prabhupāda sailed to America in 1965
Ādi Badrī	A transcendental realm accessible only to realised souls, higher than Badrī Nārāyaṇa; location of Vyāsadeva's āśrama where Madhvācārya received Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam

Appendix C — Glossary of Key Terms (11 March)

Jīva-tattva	The philosophical category of the individual soul
--------------------	---

Kṛṣṇa-tattva	The philosophical category of the Supreme Personality of Godhead
Māyā-tattva	The philosophical category of material illusion
Svarūpa	The actual constitutional identity or nature of a being
Nitya-dāsa	Eternal servant; the constitutional position of every soul
Paramātmā	The Supersoul — Kṛṣṇa as the all-pervading indwelling witness
Acintya	Inconceivable; a quality that characterises many aspects of Kṛṣṇa's nature
Digvijayī-panḍita	A scholar who travels conquering all others in debate
Bhāva	Ecstatic spiritual emotion; the beginning stage of pure love of God
Mahā-bhāva	The supreme ecstatic state; the exclusive domain of Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī
Kanthi-mālā	The tulasī neck beads worn by initiated Vaiṣṇavas
Tilaka	The sacred clay markings worn on the body by Vaiṣṇavas
Gṛhe thāko, vane thāko	'Whether at home or in the forest' — the teaching that devotional practice is available in any āśrama
Śrīvāsa-āṅgana	The courtyard of Śrīvāsa Ṭhākura's home in Navadvīpa — birthplace of the public saṅkīrtana movement
GEV	Govardhan Eco Village, Wada, Palghar district, Maharashtra (~80 km north of Mumbai)